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DECODING



SUCCESS

*Unravel the myth of success,
and find the courage to live authentically*

Acharya Prashant

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1.

INNER GROWTH FOR HIGH ACHIEVERS

Questioner (Q): The theme of today's interaction is inner growth. Usually when we talk of growth, we talk of external growth. For example, for an individual, growth usually means job promotions, better income, or more comforts, etc. For a company, growth may mean growing in profits. For an institution, it may mean better rankings, greater enrollments, etc. And for an economy, it may mean higher GDP, employment, and so on. So, given this context for external growth, how do we define inner growth for a human being, and what is its relationship to external growth?

Acharya Prashant (AP): You talked of external growth. What does that usually consist of? We earn, we accumulate, we learn, we gain knowledge, and we gain experience. And most of it we call as external growth, which is all very fine. It is just that along with it we need to keep asking: For whom is the accumulation? For whose sake are we gaining experience or knowledge or money or power? And when you ask that question, then the whole situation shifts to a different plane. Because obviously we do not earn money or gain power for the sake of money or power; we do not gain knowledge or experience for the sake of knowledge or for the sake of experience. We do it all for ourselves. We do it for our own welfare.

So, that question 'for whom?' is extremely important. And when you ask that question, you discover that even when you are striving for external growth, you, the person, the striver, the seeker is actually at the center of all your efforts. And like in any process that consumes effort, time, energy, and must produce a certain output, here in this process also, the process of external growth, we need to keep measuring whether that external growth process has delivered the final output, and the final output is the welfare of the self.

I go for money, I go for power, I want to learn something. I do it for myself. So, even as I go about accumulating all that I do in the world, I need to

constantly ask myself to what extent has it really benefited me. So 'I', the subject, is at the center of all that I do with respect to the various objects in the world. So, that is inner growth: being able to clearly see to what extent have all my worldly external endeavors facilitated my internal well-being.

Now, what is this thing, internal well-being? You see, we are born with certain tendencies and those tendencies do not let us stay at peace. If you look at a newborn baby, it already has fear, it already has greed in a rudimentary, in a nascent form. Primordial jealousy, ignorance—these things are already present in us even as we are born. And these tendencies, these physical tendencies become all the more harmful and exacerbated under the influence of social conditioning, because as we go through life we gather experiences, we gather knowledge, we gather a sense of right and wrong, and mostly that does not come from places that can help or further our inner growth.

So, internally we all need a lot of work because internally we all have a preexistent mess even as we begin the journey of life. That mess needs to be cleaned up, that inner chaos needs to be sorted out, and that is inner growth. So, inner growth is essentially a process in which you reduce or drop or rectify or cleanse a lot of stuff that you were born with; a lot of stuff that you later on, unfortunately, picked up along the process of life; stuff that was not worthy of being picked up, yet it did get into your inner system.

So, inner growth, then, is a misnomer. It is not a process of growth, actually. Nothing grows, nothing becomes bigger in inner growth. In inner growth there has to be a reduction, a simplification. In inner growth you drop a lot of things, you become smaller internally, like a tumor you are carrying within. When do you say you have grown in health with respect to that tumor? When the size of the tumor reduces. So, that is inner growth: the size of the inner tumor has to reduce.

All external efforts have to be made keeping this inner metric in mind: "Stuff that I am doing externally, in business, in profession, in relationships, with respect to books, knowledge, whatsoever I am doing from morning till evening every day, to what extent is it contributing to reducing me from within?" That is how you should look at the utility, the efficacy of whatever you have been putting your time and energy into. "I gave it so much time, I gave it energy, I worked on it. Did it really help me in an internal way?"

Because I did not do it for doing's sake; I did it because I had a strong internal reason." And that is the only reason really that one can have because we all exist within ourselves.

So, all that we do is fundamentally for our sake. I know I am being repetitive here but it needs to be emphasized. All that we do is for our sake. "I do not exist outside of myself, so I need to have one eye always on myself. I need to be self-observant. I need to keep asking, what is all this doing to me?" That is inner growth.

Q: When we talk of inner growth or inner wellness, it is not something that is unheard of; it is something which is in the common parlance. So, if we go to the neo-spiritual teachers, they talk of inner growth and inner wellness. But there, inner wellness is usually equated with stress relief or relaxation and techniques thereof. So, if one thinks about it, inner growth in that sense is considered important only to the extent that it supplements outer growth. Outer growth still remains the primary objective. Do stress relief and relaxation and techniques have any relevance with what inner growth means in the real sense?

AP: Good question. You see, this internal mess that I talked of—and quite dramatically referred to as an internal tumor just for the sake of effect—is not an easy thing to get rid of. We are born with it. It is a part of our body. It resides in each of our cells. These tendencies that I am talking of, ignorance, attachment, fear, greed, jealousy, and so many other things, they live within us. We are carrying them through the process of evolution. In fact, we share those tendencies with every living organism in the world. So, they are quite animalistic, these things that we carry. They are animalistic and deeply entrenched. And that, you would understand, is also the reason why so few people even attempt to get rid of these things.

When you do attempt to get rid of them, when you do undertake the mighty battle, the giant project of challenging your inner self to become better, to reduce in size, to drop all its baggage or most of it, then it is not easy. The self refuses to grow up. It wants to remain the way it was. And it says that if any growth is to happen, it must happen in the external domain. "Internally, I will remain how I have always been. Internally, I will remain afraid, I will remain insecure, I will remain covetous. But externally, I will gather this, reach there, climb to that position," and so on. That is the position, that is

the statement of the self, the inner self; you could call it the ego or whatever.

So, when you do want to grow internally it involves pain. It actually involves taking on stress for a long time, deliberately, with resolution. So, the person who really wants to have inner growth will not be afraid of stress. In fact, he will be prepared to go through stress. He will be prepared to invite stress—stress of the right kind, mind you. It is the stress of the right kind that has been truly, classically called as *tapasya* or *sāadhanā*. The very word *tapasya* at its root is *tap*, and one of its meanings is ‘going through heat’. You pass through fire knowingly so that all that is unworthy within you gets incinerated, burnt out. Obviously, your system would not like that; your system, your entrenched tendencies will oppose that. So, then there is inner conflict and you will have to bear that conflict.

I am not in favor of stress, obviously. But usually what happens is that in the name of avoiding stress we tend to avoid the right action as well. Such is man’s predicament, that right action would involve a lot of stress. Wrong action, action that is harmful to your real well-being, does involve stress. But contrary to popular belief, right action may involve a higher degree of stress than wrong action does. So, you have to be ready to take that challenge on.

The easier path is usually not the better one. Also, if one is doing in life stuff that is needless, then it would bring its own share of stress and tension along with it. Now, what happens is that there is a temptation to seek a cheap remedy to this situation, and the cheap remedy is to take an analgesic, some kind of a painkiller.

For example, I might be in a job that puts me in a lot of stress, and that stress is quite unwarranted. It is not the stress of the kind that facilitates any higher inner purpose. It is just that I am at the wrong place, in the wrong environment, wrong company, wrong people, and so I am obviously stressed out. Now, what do I do? I turn towards one of the popular meditation techniques floating in the market, and to some extent those techniques work, in a very superficial way, in a very short-term way.

So, I return from the bad job that I am doing in the night and I sit down for meditation. Or, in the morning before I leave for the office, I sit down to

meditate for half an hour and that relaxes my system to some extent temporarily and enables me to continue in that same job, same profession, same environment, which is, in fact, bad for me. Now, this kind of stress relief, this kind of meditation is actually becoming an enabler for the wrong thing.

So, there is a difference between stress and stress. Whatever one does in life, it does involve some stress. One must know the right stress to choose, just as one must know the right thing to choose in any condition, in any sphere of life. So stress is not necessarily a bad thing. Also, stress, to a great extent, is inevitable. Spirituality is not, initially at least, about avoiding stress. A state of peace starts descending on the spiritual person after a while, sometimes after a long while. But till then, one must pass through fire.

Also, please remember that peace is not the appearance of peace. The spiritual person will take on mighty projects and that will necessarily involve conflict. We are not talking of fairy tales here. We are talking of the real world, and in the real world when you want to do something important, something really meaningful, there is conflict. Peace, therefore, cannot mean an appearance of peace. Peace, therefore, cannot be about that typical peaceful face that we see on idols and in paintings and pictures and popular narratives and depictions.

Peace is something that inwardly allows you to continue doing the right thing even when externally there is a total lack of peace. Externally there might be noise, chaos, great turbulence, and still you manage to stay put—that is peace.

In that sense, peace or freedom from stress is indistinguishable from Truth, from silence, from all the great qualities that one associates with spirituality. Peace is not about carrying that sublime smile and walking around like you have nothing on your shoulders, no loads, no baggage, no tensions—no, that is just an appearance of peace. It is quite deceptive. More importantly, it is self-deceptive.

Q: It is very clear that outer growth has its own problems. When people start going for outer growth they tend to consume more, and excessive consumption leads to all kinds of global problems. In fact, scientists are

saying that unless something drastic is done, man is on the verge of extinction. But still, some amount of outer growth is necessary. As we discussed, internal growth is also important, but there is a certain amount of outer growth that is required for inner growth to happen. So, can there be a middle path somewhere, a compromise where one can have a fine balance between outer growth and inner growth? Something like sustainable consumption or something.

AP: You see, that middle point you are asking of, that great optimum, it emerges naturally on its own. All that you have to do is: you must continuously keep asking yourself whether all your external endeavors are contributing to your internal welfare. You said inner growth is ‘also’ important. That needs to be put in perspective.

Inner growth is the *only* thing that is important. It is not one of the things to be taken care of; it is the *only* thing to be taken care of.

I might be sounding a bit absolutist here, but if you will think about it, you might agree. Ultimately, you are yourself and all that you are doing is for your own sake, so what else can be important except your own welfare? It might sound selfish here but only to the point you do not meditate on the meaning of self. And when you go into what the self is really about, you might find that real and pure selfishness is not a bad word at all. In fact, it is a great thing.

So, just keep asking, “I am accumulating this, I am traveling to that place, and all of that has carbon consequences.” You know, you fly to some place, you raise a big house, you want better air conditioning, you want your second or third SUV, and all of that has its own carbon consequences. Most importantly, you want to have a baby. What is usually not mentioned or discussed in these circles is that the one thing that contributes the most violently to the climate crisis is growth in population. When you bring one body to the world, it is not one body you have brought here; it is an entire series.

So, if you want to reduce your carbon footprint by, let’s say, a hundred units, then up to seventy or eighty units of that can be achieved just by having a baby less. Otherwise, you may keep on doing things that appear quite holy, quite public-minded, even sanctimonious—they amount not to

much. As we said, seventy to eighty percent of your contribution towards arresting anthropogenic global warming can come from just refraining from having kids or having fewer kids.

So, these are the questions one has to ask. “Do I really need that global trip? Have I seen enough of my homeland? Do I really need to fly? Do I really need to plan for one more kid? Do I really need to do this, do that?” We all know, we are pretty aware people. We know to what extent carbon is released in what kind of activity. And if we are asking those questions—not the question of whether activities that I am proposing to do or planning to do would release carbon, but first the question whether the activity that I am planning to do is really needed for me—then we will find that automatically the carbon footprint of our existence would become smaller.

So, these things go hand-in-hand: right life and right kind of coexistence with the environment. A fellow who is living rightly is automatically living sustainably. So, right life and sustainable life, they go together. The corollary is a bit unnerving: If today we are leading the kind of lives that would potentially require a dozen Earths to fulfill our demand of resources, then surely we are not leading the right life. If right life is sustainable life, then surely unsustainable life has to be a wrong life too, wrong internally.

Which means that today, if our footprint is so big, if we are releasing copious volumes of methane and water vapor and obviously carbon dioxide and several pollutants as well, oxides of sulfur, nitrogen, then surely even internally we cannot be happy. We will have to accept that this equation exists. One who is polluting the environment would also not be internally joyful or peaceful. One who is contributing to biodiversity loss or hacking down of jungles would also be leading a pretty miserable internal life. The relationships would be bad, the sleep would be bad, the entire inner life would be messed up.

So, that optimum, that sweet spot would emerge where you consume and you consume rightly, where the consumption is not blind, where you know why exactly you are consuming. *Prakṛti*, nature, does quite generously allow for that extent of consumption. There is no problem. Every living being in the world does consume and does modify or manipulate, in the positive context, *Prakṛti*, nature, for its physical sustenance. Even a bird or a squirrel makes its nest. In the summers even dogs, the usual street dogs

we have around, they dig the soil to have a certain cool place for them to rest in.

So, every organism is doing certain things with the environment, with the ecology. Man, too, is entitled to do that. We don't have to really go back to the jungle. But the question is, how much are we entitled to consume? And how many of us are entitled to consume? If eight billion of us—who are going to be eleven billion in the future within the next two or three decades—if eight or eleven billion of us decide to have a per capita consumption that mirrors that of the US or Japan or Germany, then, needless to say, we are already doomed.

So, we need to be fewer. We need to be consuming with an eye on our true welfare. “Do I really need that third vehicle? What is it going to bring to my life? I already have two. What did they bring to me, and what is it that they did not bring to me that this third one would?” These are the kind of questions that an aware and intelligent person needs to ask. And when we lead a life that is very self-aware, then you find that your carbon footprint automatically goes down, even without planning.

And I would take a minute to also add a small warning here. If you do not lead internally right lives, then legislation is not going to deliver the goods. If we think that global meets and international summits or legislations from the side of governments are going to tackle this problem, it is not going to happen because governments are elected by people. It is a largely democratic world. And if people want to consume, governments will not be very effective in checking that consumption. Governments cannot antagonize people beyond a point.

So, it is the population that has to be awakened, and the population cannot be awakened just by telling them that, “You are doing all these things and that is causing harm to the environment.” They will come up with counter arguments. They will say, “Fine, we will go to Mars and settle there.” Already many of our poster boy billionaires are saying that. “The Earth is no more good to live in, so we are now going to colonize Mars. The planet we have made very inhabitable, inhospitable, so let's quit the planet.” And that is what they will say. They will say, “If there is going to be a mass extinction, it is nothing new. It has happened several times before. So why should we trouble ourselves to avert mass extinction?”

And they can come up with a lot of arguments if you just keep emphasizing on environmental welfare. They will say, “We do not want environmental welfare. Why must we care about this little speck of dust in the universe called planet Earth? We have so many other places to look at, you know. From global we will become universal.” When you used to talk of something national, they said, “We don’t want to have a national identity, we want to have a global identity.” Now that the globe has been burned down, they will say, “We want to have a universal identity, we will move to some other planet,” and then they will move to some other galaxy. Ultimately, all this will lead to just one big black hole.

So, the action has to be internal. Only that will succeed. I am not coming from a moral point of view. I am coming from a very pragmatic place. If you want success even in the external dimension, you have to begin within because that is where you are.

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2.

UNLOCKING YOUR INTERNAL SUPERHUMAN: WILL TO POWER

Acharya Prashant: When do we call somebody alive? We call somebody alive when the fellow has desire. Desire is one clear characteristic of being alive. Consciousness is desire or will.

Now, about this desire or will a lot has been said. Those who have tried to understand human mind, human life, have tried to ask, “What is it that a human being constantly keeps desiring? What is it that we want?” Because there is nobody who is alive and does not want. So, what is it that we live for? What is it within that keeps asking for stuff?

So, Arthur Schopenhauer, he would say the fundamental desire is the will to live—the will to just continue, to not die, to exist; the will to live. Sigmund Freud, he would say there was a fundamental will to pleasure—we want to have pleasure, we want to be happy, and that’s what the entire internal will system, desire system is for. Viktor Frankl said there is a will to meaning—we want to have purpose in life, we want to lead meaningful lives.

But now we come to Friedrich Nietzsche. He said the deepest desire is the will to power. And we will take up Nietzsche in the limited few minutes we have today, because the topic given to me today is your internal superpower.

So, we want to have power; that’s what Nietzsche said. What kind of power do we want? He said, “We exist so that we can be powerful. We exist so that we can exercise power.” It’s very difficult to understand what exactly he is saying. “We want, and we want to have power.” And the Nazi Germans totally misunderstood him. When he said we want to have power, they took it as the desire to have an external power. They called it as *kraft*—the name for external power: the will to have power over the world, the will to exercise power over other people, the will to own and possess resources and things and money and so many other kinds of...

So, when you misunderstand the basic desire to have power within, that's what you get—a world war. The Nazis imposed the world war upon the world because they thought the fundamental desire within, the desire that we all live for, the desire that keeps all of us alive, is to own the world. And we all have been making much the same mistake since then. We think that we exist to own the world, that the fundamental desire is the will to have external power—external power, *kraft*; German word. “Can I have enough power to call up someone and make him do things that I want him to do? Can I have power to purchase this or that? Can I have the power to influence other people?” That's what we think our fundamental will is for.

Well, no. India and the Indian knowers, thinkers, sages, have understood the will to power in a very different way since very long. They have said that the power that we want is not over the world. Yes, it is true that we want to be powerful. It is true that we feel helpless within as we are born, that there is a certain feeling of powerlessness within, a complex that makes us seek more and more power. But the power that we want to have is not over the entire world, the external world, but over ourselves. That power that you want to have over yourself is called *macht*. In Nietzsche's terms, it's called *macht*. You want to have power over yourself because the fundamental powerlessness, the fundamental helplessness is within, not external.

Well, does that mean that it's no use having worldly power—it's no use having money and influences and network and political power and such things? Well, the answer is: you need external power so that you can have power over yourself. You need external power so that you can conquer yourself. As long as external power is a tool, an aid, a method to go within and beat your internal weaknesses, external power is not only necessary but actually welcome; it's much more than acceptable. It's a duty to have external power, but only to the extent and only with the intention that you need it to conquer the enemy within, the falseness within.

So, that is what power is all about. And when you talk of the internal superpower, that brings me to a related word—Nietzsche's superman. He said, the superman justifies the existence of entire humanity; he justifies the entire flow of history. He says we exist so that one day we can become the superman. And who is the superman? The superman is one who has

conquered the animal within, who has beaten the primordial, animalistic weaknesses we are born with. That's the superman.

How do you get to become the superman? By not doing what the Nazis did. When you go in pursuit of external power, what you get is destruction of yourself and the world. And remember, the world war has not ended. I repeatedly say that we are already in the middle of the Third World War. And it's a kind of invisible, surreptitious war, so we don't come to know of it.

The destruction that the Second World War brought about was very little compared to the destruction that the current war is already daily bringing upon us. The extent of destruction is such that we are already in the sixth mass extinction phase. We are destroying not only a particular continent, not only enemy countries, but entire humanity, including all species. The number of species going extinct per day today is a thousand times higher than what the average has been over the last millions of years. That's the war we are talking of.

And that war has been foisted upon us by much the same misinterpretation that plagued the Nazis. They thought that we exist to own the world, that we must be able to impose our ideology on the world, that we must be able to please ourselves as we want. If that's what you think your fundamental desire or will is for, then mankind does not have too long to exist; maybe we are already in our last few decades. On the other hand, if you can understand that your heart beats so that you can beat yourself, that you exist so that you can be free of the mundane clutches of existence, then you are close to becoming what Nietzsche envisaged as his superman.

Now, as young people, it depends on you. What do you want to exercise your desire, your will for? Just to accumulate stuff because everybody in the family, in the society, and on the TV seems to do that and suggest as well? Or do you want to really understand your impulses, your desires, and go within and say, "Well, why do I need to be afraid? Why do I need to be insecure? Why can't I be a superman within myself?"

Power, when used for pleasing yourself, for just fattening your pocket, is not just ordinary power—it is something destructive, something evil. Whereas, the same power, the same force of desire, when it's turned

inwards and is used for self-improvement, self-dissolution, self-sublimation, becomes superpower.

I invite all of you to not remain merely a mortal human being. What you call as the normal human being is very close to being an animal—very, very close. We need to justify our existence by exceeding the normal humanness, the normal mortality. And when you do that, that's when you are a superman, and that's possible only with power turned inwards. Power, the force of desire, the same desire that you all experience every day, every moment—when that desire is turned inwards, what you get is superpower.

So, superpower is not about having ten thousand missiles tipped with nuclear warheads, or having a thirty-trillion-dollar economy, or having the fattest bank account one can dream of. Being a superpower is about not remaining the animal one was born as; not patronizing, nurturing or being afraid of the weaknesses that we carry deep within ourselves.

Superpower is about saying, “Before I conquer anybody else, I need to win myself. Yes, of course, money is important. Position, status, knowledge, all these things, resources, they are important. But I will use them so that I can justify my own birth, my own life.” Money is not an end unto itself. Resources, knowledge, power, the highest kind of job, entrepreneurship—they mean nothing by themselves. They are a method; they are a tool; they are a way so that we can enter ourselves and become what we are born and destined to become.

So, be a superpower. And the route goes within.

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3.

THE PATH TO SUCCESS

Questioner: How to get success in whatever I do?

Acharya Prashant: Success does not lie in doing any random thing. That is the first, the most important, and probably the last thing. The game is not at all about picking up some arbitrary thing to do and then investing yourself fully in it, plunging into it, spending a lot of energy, and trying to be successful. No, that is not the point.

Do you know why you are doing a certain thing? Are you sure what is worthy enough to be done? That is the moot question.

Choose the right thing to do, and in that lies success. In that lies *immediate* success. Immediate success implies that you have been successful right in the moment of the choice itself; you don't have to wait for the outcome. In fact, if you have to wait for the outcome to determine whether you have been successful or not, then you are already unsuccessful.

Choose the right option. Make the right decision. Fight the right battle. And now it doesn't matter whether you win or not because you are already victorious.

Victory lies in choosing the right road to walk. It does not quite lie in reaching the destination earlier than others. In fact, it is a frivolous comparison. "Am I reaching there earlier than others? Am I reaching there at all?" It is not about reaching there earlier than others in a comparative sense. It is, in fact, not even about reaching somewhere at all. It is about the immediate moment in which the decision is made.

The concept that we carry is that the real battle lies in the attainment of the goal. The real battle does not really lie in the attainment of the goal; it lies in the determination of the goal. What goal are you picking for yourself, and why? If you fight the wrong battle, isn't victory worse than defeat? What is the point in speeding down the wrong road? What is the point in

managing to obtain and eat huge quantities of food that your body does not need?

Do you know your real inner need? Is your decision-making aligned with your core self? That is the question to be asked. You must know who you are and what you really need, who you are when you are not defined by others, who you are when you are not ruled by your animal body. Who is it that you are? Once you know the nature of your self, you also know what your self is really asking for, longing for, and that makes your decisions; that decides what you would be choosing. That is the right decision.

Now you stand by it because you are choiceless. You have known what you really need, and there is no going back. The game is over. The choice has been made, and it is the right choice. Since the game is over, therefore there is no future; therefore you don't have to look forward to the future to know the result of the game. It was all about this moment. Did I decide rightly? If yes, game over. If no, game over. If I decided rightly, the game has already been won. If I decided wrongly, the game has already been lost.

The future holds no significance at all. The future is now a child's plaything. It will show you some situations, events will unfold, but they will not hold any deep significance for you. You may get some money as a result of your decisions, you may lose some money; you may gain respect, you may lose respect. All that will happen but on the periphery. Inside, you are already victorious if you have made the right decision. Outside, it may appear to people that you have lost a lot or won a lot depending on how the future unfolds, but you in your heart know fully well that it is not about how things show up in the future.

Irrespective of what the outcome of your decision is, the decision is right, you stand by it, you live by it, and that is success.

There is no success in chasing a stupid goal and managing to attain it. If the goal in the first place is unworthy, what glory is there in attaining it more speedily than others? And mind you, more often than not, the common, usual goals that we find people chasing are unworthy. The proof of that is that we all are dissatisfied, we all are restless, irrespective of whether we attain those goals or not. Ever seen any person satisfied with the goals that he has attained? In fact, the levels of dissatisfaction are hardly different

between a victor and a loser. The victorious one does feel satisfied for a short time, and after that the same old fire of discontentment comes to consume him again. Why? Because that which he so effortfully won or attained was probably not worthy of being chased in the first place.

So, do not ask, "How to get success in whatever I do?" You are trivializing action. You are saying, "What will I do? Whatever." No, no, no. Whatever is not what you do. You have to be extremely careful about what you do. Much more thought, much more consideration must go into what is worthy of being done.

Pause, reflect, take your time. Be open and alert and inquisitive. Life is precious. Time is not to be squandered in chasing unworthy goals.

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4.

TWO TYPES OF SUCCESSES— CHOOSE YOURS

Questioner (Q): What is success?

Acharya Prashant (AP): There are two ways in which we can look at success. The first way comes from the brain, which is a product of evolution and continuously afraid. The archetype of this kind of success is exemplified by the event of examinations. So, today you are here, a date sheet comes, examinations are announced. You prepare, you write your exams, somebody evaluates your sheets, and then on a particular day a result is put up, and that determines whether or not you are successful.

This is the first model of success. This is the model of success that 99% of the world thinks to be success: that there is something to be achieved in the future, and that something is also hugely dependent upon others: there is somebody else who evaluates you, there is somebody else who declares you successful. Situations have a great role in determining whether you are successful.

This is the first model, in which success always lies in the future and is always influenced by others. So, two things are very, very dominant in this first model, which is that success is not right now, success is in the...?

Q: Future.

AP: Future. Second, success depends not only on me but upon various external factors, external people, external situations. This is the first model of success.

What is the second way of looking at success? The second way of looking at success is: This is this moment; I am speaking to you right now. You could not possibly be listening to me in the past or in the future. I am not speaking in the past, and the future has not yet come. This moment is all we have. This is where all life is. This is where we are breathing. This is where

our heart is pumping blood. This is when we are listening. This is when life is. This is when attention is and love is.

This moment is all I have, and this moment is this moment only in attention, only when I am present to it. This moment and my presence in this moment, this is all I have; this is life. This moment makes me firmly grounded in the present instead of future.

And when I say, “This moment and *my* attention,” that rules out others. “This moment and *my* attention.” So, future is ruled out and others are ruled out, and all success, then, is in this moment, not in future, and this success is not at all dependent upon others.

The first model says, success is always in the future. The first model says, “Right now you are unsuccessful; success is always in the future.” The first model says, “Chase success.” If you are chasing success, have you not already declared that currently you are unsuccessful? Can I chase that which I already have? Can I want that which I already have?

So, if I want happiness, what am I saying? That I am...?

Q: Unhappy.

AP: If I want success, then what am I saying?

Q: That I am unsuccessful.

AP: This is the first model.

The second model says, “Life is right now, so success too must be right now. And I am free, so my success cannot be dependent upon anybody else. This moment is the exam and this moment is the result, and there is nobody else who would set a question paper and evaluate my answers. I am the only evaluator—my presence, my attention, my immersion into life. Right now, if I am present to life, I am successful. And if I am not present to what is happening, then I am a big loser.”

Have you heard the word ‘ignorance’? We usually take ‘ignorance’ to mean lack of knowledge, right? We say, “He is an ignorant fellow.” The word ‘ignorance’ actually means the capacity to ignore. And ignore what? What can you ignore? Can you ignore that which is not there at all? What can you

ignore? That which is there. Nothing else is available to be ignored, right? Only that which is there can be ignored.

Right now, what can you ignore? Can you ignore the words that are being said in the adjacent room? Can you ignore those words? You can't ignore those words because those words are not there at all for you. Are they there for you? What can you ignore right now? My words. What can you ignore right now? This environment. What can you ignore right now? This presence.

This is ignorance. This is failure. This is what is meant by being a loser. Life is going on—and it is a big festival—and instead of celebrating, I am ignoring it; it is passing me by. There is a grand party going on, and what am I doing? I am standing at the margins and watching with a long face and drooping shoulders.

Join the party. That is what success is, nothing else. The party is not in the future. There are no results to be declared. It is right now, a grand carnival—every moment. There is no moment that does not have the potential of ecstasy—even this moment, all moments. That is success.

Success is not about setting targets and achieving them, not at all. After all, future flows seamlessly from this moment. If I am present right now, then I am automatically building a future for myself.

But then, model one of success, we said, is followed by 99.9% of the people. You too think, “Success is out there, somewhere there, and if I do that, then I can get the label of being successful,” right? Please see that you are condemning yourself to torture if you take that position. Please see that you are declaring yourself to be unsuccessful, incomplete, inadequate if you take that position.

It requires guts to take the second position. It requires guts to say that “This present is all I have, and I am living it fully. If I am reading, I am reading completely. If I am playing, I am playing completely. If I am gyming, I am gyming completely.” And that is what is success—this moment. It takes guts to take that position.

If I am in the gym, I am not worrying about exams. If I am dancing, I am not bothered about where the next meal would come from. If I am listening,

I am just listening—to hell with everything else! I am not bothered. Who cares? This is success.

Q: But there is this quote that says, “Success is when your signature becomes your autograph.”

AP: It was Shylock the Jew in *Merchant of Venice* who said that the devil can cite scripture for his purpose. And this that you are quoting is not even scripture; this is some stupid man’s imagination—a signature turning into an autograph. No wise man can ever say all these things. After all, to whom do you give autographs? To others, right? This man is saying that “Only when the others accept me as successful can I call myself successful.” This man is surely a slave of others.

With the information revolution, so much is available on the internet. Would you just take everything? Go ahead and search for quotations on any topic. Many of you are connected to us on Facebook and we put up all these quotations, right? You know, it takes an incredible amount of time to search for the right quote, to search for something that is just delightful and simple and direct. Most of what is found there is incredibly stupid—and that is being touted around as wisdom.

Your wisdom lies in being able to differentiate using your own eyes. The world will throw a thousand things at you; but, as a young man, you must stand on your own feet, look with your own eyes, and discriminate with your own mind. This ability to distinguish between wisdom and stupidity lies within you. You must exercise it.

What do you mean by autograph? You know what is meant by autograph? That others must appreciate me. That is what an autograph means, right? Standing in front of you right now, if I become bothered with whether you are appreciating me or not, then can I really speak the truth to you? If all I am aiming for is applause, will I be able to help you at all? All I will say is things, words that will please you.

Now, do you want to be pleased, or do you want to know the truth? Do you want to be pleased, or do you want to be strong? And if I am standing here aiming for autographs, aiming for acknowledgment and applause, then I am dependent upon you; I am no more a teacher.

Kindly do not aim for all such things, that “The world will give me a gold medal, recognition, this and that, some kind of prize, respectability.” Those who aim for getting things from the world surely become slaves of the world. Let the world give if it wants to; we are not bothered. If you give, it is alright. If you don’t give, even then it is alright. I am happy doing what I am doing. Why should I be bothered with autographs?

My happiness lies not in the fact that you applaud me or give me autographs. My happiness lies in the fact that my actions, my words are coming out of my understanding, that I am connected to you right now in a very close, very intimate way. And that is enough. That is sufficient.

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5.

GET SOME LOVE BEFORE YOU CHASE SUCCESS

Questioner (Q): What is success in its truest sense? How do you define success for an individual?

Acharya Prashant (AP): I need to be successful only if first of all I realize there is a shortcoming somewhere, right? Basic principles. There has to be a backdrop of failure for me to talk of success, correct? If I am already home, will I even talk of success? If I am already okay, will I talk of accomplishments? Will I?

So, when you say you need to be successful, there is a tacit acknowledgement that you are not yet successful, correct? You are not yet successful; therefore, you need to be successful, which is all okay. None of us is born successful, so we need to be successful. But I am emphasizing on that because a lot of people talk too much of success without first enquiring into what their shortcoming or need or failure is like. If I do not know my requirement, what is it that I will order in a restaurant or a megamart or some other place? The world is a great shopping mall; it might have everything to offer, but first of all I must know my own requirement.

So, all kinds of things are there and people are chasing all kinds of things, and that is called as success. But what is it that you really need? Do we pay attention to that? Do we enquire into that? Success is something we obviously all need. But what will be the definition of your personal success? Who will tell you that? Come on, please. Who will tell you that? And therefore, success is something highly, highly personal. There can be no one set criteria that fits all.

You have to figure out what is it that you lack within, and the purpose of life is to address that lack. If I lack, let's say, in knowledge, then my success lies in gaining knowledge. If I lack in faith, something as basic as faith, my success would not lie in gaining knowledge or money; it would lie in

gaining faith. If I lack in love, what is the point in becoming a successful entrepreneur? It is love you lacked, and you still lack that. Raising four new firms or factories will not address your loveless state. And a lot of people do that. “Because life is loveless, so I will start one more venture.” That won’t help you. You are treating the wrong disease; you are barking up the wrong tree.

But our education does not take us inward. School, college, UG, PG, doctorate, formal, informal—our education fails to take us inward. It’s not that the subjects that we are taught are all worthless; they are very, very important, very important. I will forever remain thankful to my schools, to IIT, to IIM, and to all the authors whose books I read; I will forever be indebted to them. But the fact remains that education of the self is far more important than all the other kinds of knowledge that we are given. And that’s something we do not have.

The result is that the person is chasing goals all her life without even knowing whether the goal is worthy enough. There is nobody who is without target, ambition, desire. All of you have to-do lists, all of you have dreams, and that’s all okay. To be human is to dream; to be human is to desire. That’s all okay, that’s fine. The question is, is your goal worthy enough? And what is it that decides the worthiness? The answer is suitability. Is your goal suitable to you or to your neighbor? The goal today is to run six kilometers. You are fifty-five kgs, the neighbor is ninety-five. Sir, don’t ape his goal. His goal is suitable not to you. You rather go to some cafe and get a sound breakfast; that’s what you need, fifty-five kgs!

But we copy others’ goals. We act as if there is a universal criteria of success. We never look at ourselves and ask, “Who am I? And therefore, what do I need?” That question is never, never raised in our classrooms: “Who are you?” ‘Self’—that word is entirely missing from our curricula. Self, self. You are taught mathematics and management and engineering, science, languages, polity, sociology, literature. But who is it that receives all the knowledge? The self, and the self is never taught. How wise is that? Please, tell me. Is that wise? That’s not wise. And therefore, after all the education, we still have very, very stupid goals. Very stupid goals.

We do not know the nature of the self. We do not know where our dreams and desires—and dreams can turn into greed very quickly, right? There is nobody who teaches us this distinction between dream and greed.

When the 2008 crisis happened—and I was just five years out of IIM at that point—a lot of my batchmates were in the same banks that collapsed. So, when that crisis happened, I was in touch with a few of them, and I noted that the ones responsible for the meltdown were all from Ivy league institutions—not just IIM Ahmedabad; I am talking about Harvard, Wharton, Kellogg, all the fancy names. And what is it that they gave to the world? A huge crisis that resulted not only in economic hardships but actually a lot of deaths. How did that happen? They were from such fancy backgrounds, and still they did something so suicidal, so childish, so irresponsible. How did they do that? Because they were not educated in the self. That's the problem.

So, you do not know the distinction between dream and greed; and the distinction is not very obvious, mind you. You need to be taught. You need to enquire. You require time to delve into that. It deserves respect; it deserves to be a course; it deserves to have textbooks; it deserves to have examinations.

Otherwise, you will keep making stupid decisions, and the goals... His goal was to build an island. The result? He sunk a hundred-year-old bank from the island. The island never came about; the bank too collapsed. But that's the goal that you inherit, right?—from the movies. “If I am successful, I will have a yacht and an island and a massive property in London. Who wants to settle down in Gurgaon or in Bangalore? Come on. London. London, that's the place. And that too not central London, it has to be the suburbs, where amenities meet the countryside.”

So, that's the kind of life purpose most people operate with. Think of this. This is somebody's life purpose. And that fellow is an IITian, then he went to an IIM, and then he did his PhD from Harvard, and this is his life purpose: “I want to buy a yacht.” Are you a kid? A four-year-old? That's how my nephew behaves; he is four. Every time I visit the house, he is like, “Toy.” He wants a toy yacht, this fellow wants a bigger yacht—what is the difference? Please, tell me. All your life your goal is a toy. “Give me a toy,

please! The next toy, the next toy, the next toy..." And you do not realize life is toying with you.

Before you run after goals, shouldn't you ask, where are your goals coming from? I am asking you, please. Had I just chosen the common goals, I wouldn't have been standing here in front of you. No, that would have been to the relief of many of you, I understand, but still. This, the point I have come to, is not at all a social point, not at all a point my education ever taught me to come to. I was all alone, very, very lonely all throughout my journey. Forget about this being an established path of movement—this is not even a very acceptable area of human activity at all. People talk of entrepreneurship; this is not even an industry.

And it took twenty years of solitude to come to this point. And that is when all kinds of goals were beckoning—not just professional, personal as well. The day my name appeared in the Civil Services list, some minister came rushing with his daughter's hand—he must have had access to home ministry, he got my address as well from the list of successful candidates—and he came in, "Nice one. Brahmin! Looks decent. Just check whether all his organs are okay." Like you check an animal, you know. That's the kind of goal the society bogs you down with. Now that you are a civil servant, get married to an influential politician's daughter. And he will have a truck load of dowry to offer, and the daughter too was good looking, not to deny that. If you have money, very easily that makes you good looking, no?

So, goal—what is it that you want in life? You must know. And that is something, I repeat, very, very personal. Because your goal has to arise from your own insufficiency. Your dream, your desire, your ambition has to be rooted in where you are still insufficient, deficient. What else can be a goal? If I am someone who is easily scared, my goal has to be: get rid of my fearfulness, correct?

There is a world outside and there is a world inside. Where do you live? I am asking you. Please, tell me. Where do you live? You actually live in the world within. Even the world outside is experienced inside. Therefore, the insufficiency has to be within; the insufficiency that you address has to be an internal thing. Therefore, the goal has to be internal. You cannot just say, "My goal is earning money." That's an external goal. Yes, the external world can offer you a path, but a path is not a goal.

Earning money, if it is, you feel, a suitable way to get rid of your fear, then do earn money. But earning money cannot be an end in itself. If earning money is a way to get rid of your fear, then earning money is okay. But earning money, I mean... I don't live there, I live in here (*pointing at his head*); and I do not know what is in here because my senses do not take me there, nor does my education. The eyes cannot look within, correct? And the role of the education is to take the student within, and education fails in fulfilling its role.

This is not my fourth appearance at IIT as a speaker; this must be twentieth or something. Back in 2011 I was here teaching the students a course called 'Self and Value Clarity'. There was a course I had designed. And I pleaded with the authorities here—it's more than a decade, I do not exactly remember all the details, but I came here at least ten times then, 2011 it was. A few recordings are in fact available. If you will go to YouTube, you will find some of those sessions. Some ten, twenty, or thirty students sitting in a classroom, and I am talking to them, and the topic is 'the self'. Because my experiences were constantly telling me, "We lack in this, we lack in this." And because my ecosystem consisted of, comprised of people from IIT, from IIM, so I had seen that it is this place that needs that thing the most. So, I chose to address this place, typically IIT Delhi, because it is my alma mater.

Goal-setting is life-setting. If goals go wrong, life goes wrong. Your goal is everything. Take more than twelve and a half seconds in determining your goal, please. That's how we determine our goal. "Okay, so what is it that you want? What is it that you want? What is it that you want? (*Pointing at different listeners*) Okay, let's take an average. Let's take an average of what everybody else wants, and that becomes my want. Oh, he is quite famous, and he is quite powerful, and he is elderly. So, let's take a weighted average; these people will have double the weight— $2x$ plus y plus $3z$ divided by 6, that becomes my goal." How responsible is that?

You live as yourself, right? We have relationships, we have this, we have that. But ultimately you have a solitary existence here, in here (*pointing at the head*), right? And you exist for the sake of your own liberation, correct? When you die, nobody else dies with you. When you suffer, frankly nobody else can suffer with you. Oh, they can empathize, that's okay. And you are

born alone, so your goal cannot be a communal goal; it cannot arise from society, community, tradition, or such things.

Q: What if we are failing in getting success? We are trying hard, sometimes we are getting distracted also, sometimes we get back on track.

AP: The real goal is so big, so immeasurable that you will anyway never fully reach it. But its uniqueness lies in its beauty. You just keep going towards it even if you fail a million times; it leaves you choiceless, optionless. I just said that this is my twentieth year since my PG. What am I doing all these years? Till around three or four years back, who knew this unworthy fellow? Nothing!

What keeps you going then? What makes you stay put? Love. The beauty of that which calls you, compels you. And the very indispensability; you cannot do away with it; you have seen it, you have fallen for it, and now you cannot ditch it. Whereas, when your goal is trivial, petty, then you will get disappointed very soon. Also, instead of changing your approach, you will change the goal itself.

I used to find it very surprising when people would start a concern and then sell it off in the fourth year. So, you started a company, and then probably were able to bring an IPO, and then earned lots of money, and you said, “Now I am selling it off.” It was impossible for me to even think of selling off that which I started—not that there were any buyers anyway, but even if there were any buyers, I would have never even dreamt of selling it off. How can you do that? It’s a love affair. And without that, how do you manage to live?

And I was failing all the time, constantly failing, constantly failing, and that gave me all kinds of thoughts, but never the thought that I should do something else; that thought never, never came to me. I would have very happily tolerated living a life of complete failure for the next forty years even. Let’s say I would live to the age of seventy. I would have been very happy constantly and daily failing till the age of seventy, but I would have never changed the goal; I would have tried out different things. If I have some intelligence, if I have brain cells to think, I would change my approach—I will do this, I will do that, but I will never sell off that which I love.

There must be something in your life that you cannot compromise with. There must be something non-negotiable. Do you understand that? If there is nothing non-negotiable in your life, then it's a very sold out life. All else is negotiable; not that you have to be a bigot or a stubborn fellow who has no flexibility. You must be able to compromise on everything except one, and that one thing is your goal. "This is what I want," and that is possible only when, I said, the goal is large enough and compelling enough, beautiful enough. The goal must be able to enthrall you, captivate you. You say, "Finally I got something I can live for and die for." And then failure is not a big problem.

I have spoken to empty halls with just three unwilling, unfortunate ones in attendance, and I have done that dozens of times. I was never cursing my luck. There were moments when I didn't have money to get my bike refueled. It's okay, fine. It's a conscious choice; nobody has inflicted that on me. And would have been very easy at that moment to beat my chest and say, "Oh, I have abjectly failed! And I will either change the goal itself or commit suicide!"

I am not trying to set myself up as a role model or something, but I just can't help myself remembering my own failures at this moment. And I don't want you to succumb to the so-called failures. If the goal is right, the goal itself is the victory. Once the goal is rightly set, you are already victorious. Now, how can you fail? And if the goal is wrong, then you will be a failure even after all your victories.

You boarded a train and came a thousand kilometers—that must be some great distance covered, right? What if the train is the wrong one? All your successes are just your sob stories if your goal itself is wrong. You have traveled a thousand kilometers indeed, but you have reached the wrong destination. You never wanted to reach there; that destination will give you nothing.

Yes, do travel. There must a lot of rigor and intensity in your life. You must live a very happening and active life, but the first and the most important thing is that the goal has to be right. Also, lest it scares you, you will not get the goal right in one go. It's a process of experimentation; the goal evolves. So, do not be too apprehensive—"What if the goal is wrong?" Give

yourself time. See what matters to you, apply yourself to that, stay with that, and then revisit, review, modify. You have that freedom.

Failure etc. don't mean anything; they just mean that the game is on. The game is already won, and now the game is on. "I am already victorious in advance—who can defeat me now?" That should be the approach.

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6.

DECISION-MAKING MASTERY: YOUR KEY TO LIFELONG SUCCESS

Acharya Prashant: I am at point A, and point A, whatever it is, wherever it is, never succeeds in giving me full satisfaction. Is that true for all of us? Wherever we are, that point is never a point of complete satisfaction for us, correct? And that's the reason we need to move to some other point. Now, the question is, which other point? Which other point and what route to take to that point? That is the foundation of entire decision-making.

So, whenever we need to take a decision, we need to be firstly thinking of where we currently are, not where we want to reach.

You see, usually when you have to decide, you only talk of the options, right? You say, "I have to make a decision, and these are the options available; and among these options, I have to make a choice." Correct? So, let's say the names of the options are B, C and D. And I have to make a decision between these three: B, C and D. I am continuously thinking, therefore, of B, C and D. Which one to choose? Which one to choose? Is B better? Is C better? Is D better? Pros, cons. And if I am picking up one of these, which route to take to that destination?

The mind is totally occupied in this kind of thought, deliberation—B-C-D, B-C-D, B-C-D. Sometimes C appears great, and then someone comes and says, "No, B is wonderful. Look at me!" And just as you were about to decide in favor of B, suddenly D shows up as the most lucrative one. And we keep just hopping from one option to the other.

In life, it could even be E, F, G, H, X, Y, Z. What is missing in this entire thought process? Right from B till Z, the entire alphabet has been covered. We are thinking of all the options possible to us. What is the one little thing that is missing there? The first thing, the starting point, the most important

thing. But it is always missing because it is exactly where we are and the eyes only look somewhere else.

The eyes have no capacity to know exactly where you are. The mind is always busy thinking of the future and other places. The mind does not like to introspect, reflect and know what the current reality, the present facts are. The mind does not like doing that. The mind has much more fun dealing in imaginations. Imaginations are dearer because they make you feel empowered: “No, I have so many choices. I am an empowered person.” And each of the choices offers and promises pleasure. And A is not a point of pleasure.

What is the definition of A? We said, A is a point of dissatisfaction. We stand at A, and we are continuously dissatisfied wherever we are. So, A is a point of dissatisfaction, and from B to Z, there is the promised satisfaction of various kinds—B promises satisfaction of B kind, and T promises satisfaction of T kind. But A is a point of dissatisfaction. So, the mind is continuously thinking of B, C, X, Y, Z. A it will never know of.

But if you do not know the very story of your dissatisfaction, the details of your current situation, will you ever be able to take care of your internal problems? If you go to a doctor and he starts prescribing you medicines without diagnosing you, without asking for a pathology report clearly explaining your current situation, what kind of doctor would that be?

So, all of us are actually bad doctors to ourselves. We do not like to diagnose our current condition, but we want great medicines so that we can be healthy and powerful and beautiful in the future. But how can you prescribe yourself a course of betterment if you do not know what your current ailment is? ‘Ailment’ you understand? Disease, problem. If I do not know what my current problem is, how will I have a solution to that problem?

But look at the way the mind functions. The mind does not want to go into itself; the mind does not want to go into its current state, and its current state alone is the problem. The mind does not want to go into that because it hurts, no? It hurts, and it requires a certain discipline, a certain watchfulness. Instead of watching what is going on, the mind wants to deal

in colorful imaginations: just forget what is going on and start thinking of the various possibilities and colors and pleasures possible.

Therefore, the first step in decision-making is to ask yourself, “Why do I need to make a decision? What is wrong with my current situation?” This appears like a very obvious question, but we fail to ask it most of the times. Why? First of all, is there a need to go away from A to any other place? What’s wrong with A? And obviously, there is something definitely wrong with the place A.

Are we together? Or are we all lost in this alphabet? Somebody is at M, somebody is at X. Are we all together at A? That’s where we need to be.

So, first of all, why do I need to decide? If everything is hunky-dory, perfectly good, A is my home, I don’t need to move an inch. But there is something certainly wrong with A. What is my current situation? The more you go into it, the more clearly it emerges where you need to go next. And if you do not go into A and just keep thinking of possibilities and alternate destinations, you will be just entertaining yourself. You will feel good, but that feeling will lead you nowhere.

We will talk of so many things—you know, five-year plans, visions for the future; you hear them everywhere. Right from the ordinary household to the parliament of India and the United Nations, everyone is talking of the place to go *to*. But we do not talk as much of our real, current situation and why at all we are stuck in the situation that *is*.

There must be a reason why we are at A, right? There must be a reason. And if we do not address that reason, it is quite possible that even if you move to D, D will be nothing but another form of A. Because the reason you are at A might be an internal reason, not an external reason. Your problem might not be external. The problem usually is not external.

Wherever you are at in life is because of something within you. Please note this down.

Now, you want to go to some other place, but you are carrying the reasons why you were at the previous place, firstly; even if you go to the other place, not much will change in your life. But we want to change exteriors. “I am not feeling well; the house looks dull.” So, what do we change? We

do not change the mind of the occupants of the house; we change the paint, we change the curtains. Don't we do that? But what if the problem is right within you?

If you know where the problem is, then you will know what is it that you really need to address.

All our life we fight, we struggle, we strive. We want to be better, so we toil so much, don't we all do that? Homo sapiens all work so hard in life. You go to the jungle, you do not find any other species working so hard; but we work very, very hard. Animals move about just either for food or for pleasure or for mating, and that's all. They don't really indulge in organized work. But we keep working almost sixty-seventy percent of our life. But still, no animal is as depressed and as dissatisfied as human beings are. There has to be a reason.

This is the reason: we move from place to place without ever understanding the problem.

So, "I want a solution, I want a solution, I want a solution." But what is the problem in the first place? That we never bother to clarify to ourselves. We just have a vague impression, all of us. We have a vague impression. And if you have a vague impression of the problem, all you will get is vague solutions. And vague solutions you have aplenty.

The world is nothing but a huge marketplace of possible solutions. Everyone is selling solutions to you. And in lieu of the solutions they sell you, they charge huge amounts of your life, your time, your effort, your money, your everything. How are people able to sell all kinds of solutions to us that don't work? Because we do not know our problem. When you do not know your problem, any solution appears possible and lucrative, does it not?

You pick up a GPS system, let's say, Google Maps. You put in it the place you want to go to. Would it work for you? Let's say you have connectivity and all that—would it still work for you? It won't. It will ask for your current location. We do not know our current location; we just want to reach somewhere. And we keep wondering, "But I have written it: I want to reach the states. The Silicon Valley is the place I belong to!" The GPS, even the GPS happens to be wiser than most of us. It will refuse to respond. It will

say, “No. No answer. First of all, you should know where you are; otherwise no route is possible. No movement.”

We do not know where we are, so everything appears a possible solution. There is a certain dissatisfaction within me, and that dissatisfaction is the characteristic of point A, right? Now, someone comes and says, “Alright, let’s go watch a movie.” That appears like a possible solution. Someone comes and says, “Let’s go settle on Mars.” That too appears a solution. Now, think of this. Settling on Mars appears a solution, and so does just going and watching a movie. Does that not tell of total ignorance about our inner state?

Someone says, “Let’s go. Let’s have a game of table tennis.” That too appears fine. Maybe this will work. Someone comes and says, “You just sleep for two more hours, you will be alright.” That too appears worth trying. Someone says, “Oh, you don’t have a nice mate in your life. Go get a girl. Go get a boy.” That too appears quite promising; maybe that will take care of the internal unrest. Then some senior comes and says, “Dude, all you need is a high-paying job. And once you have that, you will start feeling good within.” And you say, “Oh, now I know; that was the problem!”

The world, we said, is a huge marketplace that keeps on offering all kinds of unworkable solutions. They will not work, not because the world is hell-bent on cheating us, but because we do not know what we need. Do we know what we need? Instead of discussing where we need to go, more than half the time, the energy in the decision-making process should be invested in knowing where we actually stand currently.

But the mind has ego at its center. “I know. I already know. Of course, this is where I am. Am I such a fool that I won’t even know the ground under my feet? Of course I know! What is it that I do not know? Oh, I do not know that and that and that and that (*pointing in various directions*). So, those are the places I need to go to and try. But this, this, my current situation, I of course know of that! I am living it. Who else will know of it? I am the master of my life. I know everything, what is going on.” No sir, that’s not true.

If there is one thing each of us is deeply ignorant of, it is our own mind. That's the one secret hardly anyone is able to unravel.

We might know of a thousand things in the universe; a day might come when science might know everything under the sun. But still, the most fundamental unit, the entity that sees everything, will remain like a black box. You know of everything, but the one that knows of everything will remain unknown. All the mysteries outside have been opened up and solved, but this, the black box? *(Shakes head)*

So, internally we will continue to remain at point A. Externally, we have covered not only the alphabet, but the entire dictionary. All the possible permutations, combinations, everything meaningful and meaningless has been tried. And yet we are in the same sad and sorry state as we ever were.

A few data points for you all. The world is more prosperous today than it ever was in its history. Per capita incomes were never as high as they are today, and that's when we are talking of a population of eight billion people. Eight billion people with the highest possible level of per capita income, and those per capita incomes are only increasing at a global average rate of around three percent per year. In developing countries, the rate of increase of per capita income is often seven percent, eight percent, nine percent. China actually experienced ten percent for several consecutive years.

The kind of technology that we have today, the power of information at our hand, has no parallel in history. And we are living longer. Average age lifespans in several European countries and Japan are already touching ninety years. The average fellow is living almost up to ninety. Even in India, it has exceeded seventy-five years already. There are so many countries in the world that have almost absolute literacy now. In India, too, in several states, literacy levels have now exceeded ninety percent.

We should be very, very joyful. This should be the golden period of human existence, no? We have gone to the moon. We are going to Mars. We have thousands of man-made satellites orbiting the Earth. And you have thousands of channels available for your entertainment. Science is even trying to make man almost immortal. If not immortal, then make people live up to one fifty years. There is no disease so big that man is not

challenging it and trying to find a solution. Even HIV/AIDS almost has a cure today. We all should be extremely delighted.

Man is God. We have done that no previous generation could. And Man is more depressed today than he ever was. Mental disease is today a kind of epidemic that it never was. Suicide rates today are higher than they ever were. We have more nuclear weapons ready to be fired than ever. And we are closer to a complete climate catastrophe than we ever were. We are wiping out more species today than we ever were. In the last forty years, we have completely obliterated more species than got extinct in the last forty thousand years. And that might be an underestimation. If you Google, you might find that it is actually four million years. The number of species that went extinct in the last lakhs of years is very small compared to the number of species we have completely wiped out—they will never return—in just the last four decades.

What's going on? These should be the best of times. Instead, these are the worst times man has ever faced. Not merely man, all the species on this planet. In fact, the planet itself has never faced a worse condition than it faces today. And we live longer, we have more money, we have more technology, we have more knowledge, we have more power to destroy. You ask for it, you have it. You want to reach a place, you reach faster. You want to order a good, it gets shipped faster. What is it that you want? Tell me, you will have it.

Everything is available, right from B till Z. And yet we are unhappier today than we ever were. We are not only at A—we have sunk to a place below A.

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7.

A SINGLE MANTRA FOR SUCCESS

Questioner (Q): Many of my friends say that optimal allocation of resources is the best way to achieve success. How can spirituality help us achieve the optimal allocation of resources so that we may achieve success easily?

Acharya Prashant (AP): Let's say I am drunk and I am to allocate resources to ten of my priorities. There are ten channels in front of me each demanding resources, and I only have a finite sum with me to divide and allocate to each of them, and I am drunk. What will I do? I will probably allocate the lion's share to the liquor vendor, no? I have ten thousand rupees and I have ten things to take care of. And in a drunken state, this is the kind of allocation I will do: out of the ten thousand rupees, I will probably allot eight thousand to liquor supply. You know what this discussion is going towards.

So, in any act, the actor comes first. In allocation, the allocator comes first. Spirituality is about purifying the actor, the allocator. If I am alright, then I will know my priorities and I will also know their relative importance, because I will know the one thing that is of prime importance. Knowing that one thing, I will know everything else in the context of that one thing. If I know the Truth is very important, then I will know the direction help towards Truth is going to come from, and I will pay maximum attention to that and allot maximum resources to that.

Spirituality is about first of all knowing your central priority. Your central priority is Truth or freedom—'freedom' is a better word, I am talking to youngsters. Your central priority is freedom.

Now, having known that freedom must be of prime concern in life, and having known that right now you are not at all free—you are in bondage in so many ways, inner and outer—what do you want to give your time, energy, money, and life to? These are your resources, right? Your intellect,

your time, your money, your energy—these are your resources; the biggest resource is time itself.

Now, what do you want to give your time to? Having known that freedom is the most important one in life and you are not free right now, what do you want to give your time to? What do you want to give your money to, your energy to, your youth to? You want to give your time to procuring the axe. Don't you want to do that? You want to sharpen the blade—that is what you want to pay money for. And now you know how to allot your resources. Now you don't want to pay ten thousand rupees to the liquor vendor. Now you don't want to invest your entire savings in a trip to Goa. I hope you don't go to Goa for liberation or freedom from bondage. If you do, then it is another matter!

So, it is not about what you do, it is about who does it. That is self-knowledge. “I am doing something, I am attending to something, I am rushing towards somewhere—who am I when I am doing that? What is causing the desire to do this or that?” Go to the root of your desire and figure out where it is coming from.

And I am not talking metaphysics here. Our desires are not metaphysical; our desires are very very physical. See where the desires are coming from; see who implanted that desire in you; see who told you that such one thing is called the good life; see who provided you the blueprint, and then you will see how deeply you are in bondage. Everything about you is coming from somewhere else.

Once you see you are in bondage, you will not at all like it. You will not like it, and when you will not like it, you will know what to put effort towards. That is resource allocation.

Q: Sir, you used the word ‘desire’. In pursuing desire, there are usually two possible outcomes: one, I will be trapped in a cycle of constantly running after something without ever getting any satisfaction from the achievement; two, if I fail to get what I want, I fall into depression. So, both outcomes of desire are harmful, regardless whether I get what I want or not. How to deal with this? Can desire be useful somehow in the spiritual process?

AP: You see, obviously you cannot be fulfilled and yet be crazy with desire, right? Desire requires unfulfillment. You need to have a certain itch, a

certain vacancy, a feeling of incompleteness, and only then you will be desirous of something.

So, desire comes from there, that inner hollow. That inner hollow, classically, is called the ego. The ego is like a free radical: it is unstable, it cannot just exist by itself, it cannot be alone. It always requires something to bond with; it requires company, it requires something to attach itself to, be identified with. And that is desire: thinking that something in the world will suffice to make you feel fulfilled, rushing after objects believing that one or more of them will give you completeness, failing in the attempt, yet not acknowledging your central mistake—that is desire.

Can desire be useful in the spiritual process? Can it lead to upliftment or betterment of a young person, or any person? Yes, of course.

Now, there are two kinds of desire. One, where you want to just follow the configuration of the desirous entity—what is the configuration of the desirous entity? It is incomplete, that is the configuration. It has an incomplete configuration. Now, one kind of desire just exists to extend the incompleteness: “I am incomplete, and I am desiring an object that will keep me incomplete.” This is foolish desire, and this is desire that prevails the most. So, 99.999999% of our desire is that. Most people desire this way, most of the times. This desire is self-defeating, because all desire desires fulfillment but chooses in such an unwise way that it can never have fulfillment. The object of desire has to be chosen very carefully.

Now you would have guessed what the second kind of desire is. The other kind of desire desires to unravel itself; it doesn’t desire to keep itself intact. The first kind of desire followed the configuration of the desirous entity; the second kind of desire exists to demolish the desirous entity. And in the demolition of the desirous entity lies the fulfillment of the desirous one.

Your desire is to come to an end, to a final fulfillment. Your desire is to come to a point after which you don’t have to desire anymore. And if you don’t have to desire anymore, that will be the end of the desiring one. So, in a sense, we all desire our end, not physical so much but psychological.

So, that is why you have to be very discreet, very wise when choosing your desires. In fact, there has to be choice in the first place. Mostly we don’t even have a choice in our desires; our desires are blind and powerful waves

that just carry us away. First of all, develop a choice. Learn to say yes and no—more importantly, no.

Learn to say no to desires. Be discreet in saying yes. And when you say yes to a desire, give it all your energy, time, passion, resources. It must be worth it, first of all. Otherwise, desire is a great dissipation. You will have twenty thousand desires in a day and you will just waste yourself rushing after each of them.

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8.

MY SUCCESS MANTRA

Questioner (Q): You are an inspiration and an idol for many of us. Lots of successful people on the internet whom we follow often share their rules for success. So, what is your success mantra?

Acharya Prashant (AP): I do not know whether it's a success mantra, but yes, this is a discipline that I follow, irrespective of whether it yields me success or failure in the conventional sense of the word. And the discipline is to follow my understanding or my conviction. I try to stick to what I have seen to be right.

It is possible that at times my seeing itself is blurred and I do not quite get to differentiate between real and unreal; that is possible. But what I try to minimize is knowing and yet not doing. So, if I do not know and then I did not act, that is possible; but if I know and I still do not act, then I hold myself guilty. And one wants to minimize guilt, right? So, that's what.

And it's a simple discipline to follow, is it not? Once you know something to be right, don't budge, don't shake, don't falter; don't come up with an excuse; don't say, "Yes, this is right, yet I did not live up to it." If that happens, that to me becomes a cause of internal culpability, a kind of shame, something that takes away from my humaneness. So, those instances have to be minimized, and that's what my attempt is.

So, first thing, try to understand, try to know as much as possible. Your enquiry must be unrelenting. There would be things you would feel hesitant to know about because you would have an apprehension, an intuition that knowledge might turn out to be dangerous. Ignorance is more suited to the ego most of the times. So, you will find stuff in front of you that you would not want to question. Not that you *cannot* question it, but that you do not *want* to question it; you do not want to probe what is going on.

And I said you will find stuff like that in front of you; that's not the best way to put it. You will find most of the times that kind of stuff inside you,

and you will want to pretend as if everything is sorted, as if there are no blind spots, as if you know most of what needs to be known. But that's, as we said, just a pretense. Somewhere you know that you are avoiding knowledge. Now, don't do that.

Never be afraid of knowing. There is no way to know except to very impartially and fearlessly enquire, ask, experiment, try, test, probe—all the classical ways.

So, you will have to do all these things. And these things will obviously yield results and the results are often not very palatable. The results are more or less the way you apprehended. You already had an inkling that the results might upset you, and they do. Even if knowledge upsets you, still do not discard it. Stick to it. Honesty is one of the basic touchstones that determine the degree of your humaneness.

Q: Honesty to yourself?

AP: Honesty to what you already know. See, you can be excused to an extent for not knowing, because we are born with primordial ignorance, right? So, you really are not obliged to know everything that is possible to be known. And practically, it's not ignorance that destroys most people; it is the dishonesty that destroys them.

Even if you are quite ignorant, you still know a lot; you still know a lot about yourself, your life, your relationships, your decisions, your experiences—you have all this. So, you might not be well versed in the scriptures, you might not be on top of great literature, you might not be a great mathematician, or a linguist, or a historian—you might not know all these things in great depth or detail, but you have lived a life, have you not?

So, let's say you are twenty, twenty-five, thirty, whatever. You have all these years, and you have a consciousness that is experiencing every moment, right? So, you indeed do know a lot. It's not that you are rank ignorant or dead ignorant. So, that's why I said ignorance is not the fundamental problem. It's a big problem, definitely. You should try to know as much as possible. We talked of experimenting, trying, testing, probing, enquiring; all that is what yields knowledge. So, we talked about that. And having said that, we are saying ignorance is only the number two problem. The number

one problem is dishonesty. And that's my mantra—to avoid the number one problem.

What you have seen must not be unseen. What you have heard must not be unheard. What you have known must not be unknown. The conviction of one moment should not become an ignored entity another moment. What you have promised yourself in the light of your understanding one moment should not become a forgotten thing some other moment. If at this moment you are attentive and your attention is yielding you a certain understanding, stay committed. Now that you have known, commit yourself to what you have known. Do not budge.

So, it's not that people never know the heights of understanding, realization, of consciousness. No, it's not that way. It's just that they do not stay there because they do not love those heights enough. So, even if in a moment they find themselves right on the peaks of their being, of their possibility, they just don't value, respect, and love those peaks enough to stay there for long or permanently. What you do not value, you do not retain for long, or do you? Even if you get something very, very precious and you do not value it, how long will that thing stay with you?

So, there has to be love. And with respect to love, I am using the words commitment, honesty, integrity, a certain innocence, a certain innocence that does not deceive itself. You do not tell yourself, "Yes, right, I understood. I said I could see, but you know, right now there are other priorities." So, these things all go together—love, honesty, innocence, commitment, integrity, value.

And the opposite of all these is a kind of shallowness that vibes very well with smartness. "I am so smart. In a field of understanding, I said I understand because that's what the field did to me. So, I said I understand. And the moment the field was gone and I was in a certain other ambience, I started belonging to that other place, that other environment." This fickleness, this centerlessness is no good. No good.

So, stay put. Stay put. Stay committed. Be ashamed of changing colors too often. Don't be a spiritual chameleon. In front of the teacher, or when with a great book or a scripture, you turn all meditative and attentive and loving and wise. The moment the climate changes, you are somebody else. "No,

no, no. I avoid being somebody else.” There must be something within you—please, you must learn this as a young man—that simply does not change.

Obviously, externally, peripherally, a lot about you will change and must change. The body will grow, develop, then age, then die; so, there is change. The student will become a professional probably; so there will be change. And there will be experiences; so there will be change. But there must be a certain sacred spot within that must not change. And that sacred spot within, being sacred, must be your identity. That’s who you must be.

I am not saying that your ideology must not change. No. I am not saying that all the identities one walks around with must not change. No. I am not talking about all those things. Let them change. I am talking of something that really knows, something that realizes, something that is higher than everything else, something that you do not want to trade, barter, sell, auction, or even display to the world. That sacred something must always be there. And that sacred something must be your identity, your father, also your strictest judge.

The world can be deceived—that sacredness cannot be. And the goal of life must be to stay innocent in front of that sacred inner judge. The world can respect you or abuse you; the world can convict you or decorate you. Ultimately what matters is how you are to yourself, no? One lives within; all your experiences are within. That has to be kept in mind.

The party will be over sooner than later, and I am to live with myself. All these people will disperse. And if I have to be with myself, I better not do stuff that makes me guilty in front of myself. And again, I am not talking of conscience either; I am not talking of having a conscience. What I am talking of, that’s probably not too easy to express, but I hope I have communicated something.

9.

STOP FAILING, SUCCEED NOW

Questioner (Q): My question is related to failures. I have always been a very positive-minded person, and I have been trying my best to do everything that I can and give my best to everything. But still, I am disappointed with myself. I feel that there have been a lot of failures in my personal and social life. I try hard to please people, I try to give my best in a relationship, but what I get is disappointment and dejection. I don't know how much I can recover myself, because every time after I fail, it weakens me internally. Even if I try to stand up once again and work more, I don't have the same spirit.

So, I want to know how to tackle this issue. What approach should I take in my life to overcome these failures and succeed?

Acharya Prashant (AP): You don't need an approach to deal with failure; you need reality.

You see, you wanted to do something. If you wanted to do something, there must have been a reason; or are you just randomly pushing yourself into something? That doesn't happen, right? If you don't do that thing, if you don't attempt doing that thing, you suffer. That's the reason why you are doing that thing. What you are attempting is important; that's why you are attempting it. If you don't attempt it, you won't feel good. If you don't attempt it, there would be a hollow within. So, that's your situation when you start. "I am suffering, that's why I am acting."

Now, when you act to relieve your suffering, you push yourself into the action to relieve your suffering. The action demands a price to be paid, and the price to be paid includes failures—failures in terms of results. You wanted to do that thing a particular way, you wanted your project to take a certain form, but it doesn't take that form; so you suffer. Now, the question is, which suffering is bigger? You have to remember that. It's a relative situation. If you look at only one suffering, it will appear too big.

Do you get which two sufferings we are trying to compare? The suffering that first of all impelled you to do what you are doing, to pick up the project. So, there is a suffering that pushes you to pick up that project. If you don't pick up that project, you will suffer even more. But when you do pick up that project, that project brings in its own wake suffering of its own kind. Now, this suffering starts appearing very big sometimes. It starts appearing big because you tend to forget the mother suffering that firstly pushed you into this project.

If failure is so very painful to you, then don't act at all. Any project that you pick up, if it's worthy enough, carries a significant risk of failure. And the risk of failure looms large irrespective of how worthy the project is. In fact, it's possible that more worthy projects carry a higher risk of failure. And if failure pinches you too much, then I am saying, don't act at all. Why act at all? Because failure carries a large probability of happening. You know in advance that there is a ninety percent chance of failure, and failure hurts, so why act at all?

But you will act. Why? Because what you are doing is important. If you don't do that, then that not doing, that inaction, will hurt you even more. We forget that; we forget the mother suffering, so the subsequent disappointments that come our way start appearing too big. "Oh, I did this, and in the process of doing this I am meeting with so much resistance and it takes so much effort. I am tired. And people are saying that I have invested two years into it and nothing is coming out of it!"

If it's all so bad, just drop it and don't do it. We forget why the thing we are doing deserves to be done in the first place; the mother reality we forget. That's why I am saying, you don't need methods to cope with your pain; you just need a dose of reality. I understand that failure hurts, hurts all of us. But how deeply would it hurt to not act at all? You tell me that.

Q: If I do not try, it will even hurt more...

AP: Exactly. So, if you have to choose between these two sufferings, choose the lesser suffering. Is not acting an option at all? Is not trying an option ever? When you start something, you very well know that there is a huge chance of failure. Irrespective of that, you start off. Don't start thinking that success is your birthright or something. And do not be taken in

by the sellers of pleasure who tell you that suffering is optional or needless or whatever.

Suffering is a fact of life. The best you can do is choose the better suffering. Choose a higher suffering. I am not saying bigger suffering; I am saying the *higher* suffering. Suffer you must because you are alive. Suffer rightly. If there is a cause worth dedicating yourself to, plunge into it, give yourself to it.

And when you do these things, a lot of circumstantial forces will strike you. When you proceed in the right direction, you will meet headwinds. There will arise a feeling within, “Why am I doing all this? Why must I needlessly invite so much trouble?” Then the way is to remind yourself that the trouble you are facing is not needless. And if at times the inner clamor grows too loud, then say, “Alright, if this seems too much to take, then I am resigning, I quit.” And then see.

Q: I cannot quit.

AP: You cannot quit; that’s the thing. Irrespective of how bad it is to continue, you still cannot quit. That’s why you must pick only the right things in life. When you pick the right things in life, then you stay put even if the road goes bad, even if the going becomes quite difficult, because you know in the first place and you can remember very well what made you start off.

Always have a solid reason to start off. Don’t randomly throw yourself in any direction. And never, never expect a trouble-free life. I am guaranteeing you in advance. If the cause is worth it, then troubles will be plenty. In fact, chances are if you pick up something very trivial, something quite worthless, then you will have a relatively trouble-free life. Is that what you want as a young man?

Q: No, I want my ambitions to come true.

AP: Great! First of all, pick your ambitions wisely. Know very well why the things that you want deserve to be wanted. Be very choosy and very discreet in deciding your goals. Most of the things that tempt us and attract us don’t really deserve to be pursued.

So, be extremely wise, extremely mature, and very patient in knowing what deserves your attention and your perusal. And as you gain in clarity, as you zero in on your goals, you will find that you are now imbued with an inner inspiration that cares for no obstacles, because that inspiration is coming from a deep clarity, a clarity that will be prepared to accept all sufferings along the way.

Only when your goal is not coming from your heart will the sufferings along the path become too much to take. You start complaining, you become fidgety, you become nervous, and you drop out. I am not saying dropping out is a bad thing. If you have picked up an unworthy goal due to some mistake, it's a wise thing to drop out.

So, pick your goals with caution. If you have picked them rightly and if you are still facing suffering, remind yourself of the mother suffering; remind yourself of the kind of suffering that first of all made you pick that goal, and remind yourself of what happens if you are not loyal to the goal you have picked up.

Q: Sometimes in our social or personal life, despite putting our best efforts into relationships—with parents, relatives or friends—we don't find that it's reciprocated or acknowledged. How to deal with that?

AP: Why must you do anything? Go to the fundamentals always. You do something because it is important to your inner state. Otherwise, why must anybody do anything? You help someone because that fellow deserves to be helped. You display respect to someone because the fellow deserves respect. You put something into a relationship because the relationship is worth it. And a relationship is worth it only if it nourishes the people in it.

So, ask yourself the fundamental question: Is the relationship nourishing both of us, the other person and me? You said, "I am putting a lot into the relationship." Why are you putting...

Q: For support from my family and relatives to achieve my goals and dreams.

AP: Your goals are your goals. As a young person, why do you want ratification or support from others? If that support comes, great; it's a bonus. But I don't suppose at your age others can have a great role towards

energizing you in your journey. In fact, you might discover at some point that it's a worthy project to help the people around you, and help them by correcting them. And when you try to correct them, they will offer resistance. Now, in this project, where they will face inconvenience because you are trying to correct them, would you still expect them to support you?

Q: No.

AP: That's right. Worthy projects can run only on innate inspiration. I do realize that being creatures of flesh and blood, we all are affected by what others are saying and doing. We are motivated by others' support, and lack of support makes us feel lonely; those things happen. But those things have to be kept to a limit. Otherwise, life will be an exercise in helplessness; you don't want that.

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10.

UNLOCKING SUCCESS: WHY FINANCIAL LITERACY IS A MUST- HAVE IN COLLEGE!

Questioner (Q): What is your view on the financial literacy of the current generation? Do you think that financial awareness should be added to our college curriculums?

Acharya Prashant (AP): Your generation is much more financially literate than any of the previous ones. It's just that more than finance, it is about values. You want to buy something and there can be three ways, let's say, to finance the purchase. It's one thing to know which way is the best, and it's an altogether different thing to know whether the thing is worth buying at all. That's where your generation falters.

You know a bit of finance, you do, but you don't know the value of anything. To you, finance is about knowing the price and managing the price, while life is about realizing the value; and price and value rarely go together. You have all the eyes for price; you don't have much of an appreciation of value. So, the result is that you make very, very solid financial decisions about buying or selling, rather buying worthless crap—great and very, very smart way of buying crap. The fellow has cracked a great deal in which he could manage to buy crap. The deal is wonderful, but what you have brought home is crap.

The fellow has access to an online tool and that is telling him how much he must save every month, and how much must he deposit from his quarterly bonus so that at the age of fifty he has a corpus worth retiring. But he does not know what to do till the age of fifty or after the age of fifty. He does not know what retirement means, because he never knew what work means. And if work really is work, will it ever allow you to retire? That fellow does not know that.

But what he knows quite smartly is that, “If you put this much here, this is how mutual funds operate, this is how international market operate, and I can also do some intraday trading on the stock exchange, and if I do all this quite smartly, then I will be able to save this much.” What will you do by saving that much? Yes, of course, you will manage saving all that—what will you do with that? That is a question which has never been answered. And that is the most fundamental question. Without answering that question, all other questions and answers are purely worthless.

One fellow, one of these financial influencers, a very biggie, a big one really, he was asked, “What do you think must be the direction of life for a young person?” He says, “You know, I do not think so much. All I want is that all should manage to achieve their targets.” What an answer! He says, “If everybody succeeds in achieving his targets, the nation and the society will anyway move in the right direction and there will be growth.”

But in absence of a value system, you will never realize what to pick as your target. And that’s everything—what to devote your life to? What else is life for? Life is not something that you can just sit and eat from. Life is like this body: it needs to work. If it doesn’t work, what happens to it? One great way to kill you is by confining you in a room full of luxuries and saying, “You will be given the best food to eat and no work to do, and all time to sleep and entertain yourself.” Within four or six months, you will drop dead. That tells you something about life.

Life, in some sense, is like a machine. It exists for the sake of an output. What kind of output, that’s for your discretion to decide. Life is like a car: it can’t keep standing at one place. You can’t say, “It’s a beautiful thing. Let it stand here. Let me polish it, service it; let it stand here.” We are supposed to work, toil, exert ourselves. We are supposed to exert ourselves so much that we finish ourselves off in the endeavor.

I know this is probably not the answer that you wanted; you were emphasizing on financial literacy. But there is already more financial literacy that I see among you chaps than I saw among my batchmates or in myself. So, I don’t think that’s a big concern. You fellows are already much more money-minded—without knowing what money means and without knowing what to do with that money. Not that we were any better, not that

we necessarily knew; but because you are smart chaps, so our expectations from you are higher. We were comparatively dumb, obviously.

And see where you are getting your financial literacy from. And it's not just literacy that you are getting from here and there, you are actually getting your financial objectives from the places that should give you just knowledge. Instead of knowledge, they are giving you objectives.

So, on YouTube, you have thumbnails where this so-called financial adviser is portraying himself, displaying cash like cards. So, he is standing with rupees and dollars, those notes and bills in his hands, and you are supposed to listen to him. In fact, were we a society with any sense, that thumbnail should have sufficed to kill that video. What kind of person that would be who can put himself on a thumbnail holding dollars in his hand? What are you, a *mumfali* (peanut) vendor or what? And then you buy your literacy from there. Instead of making you literate, he just makes you greedy.

Value. Understand life. See what is it that you must go after. Finance is really not so complicated. Unless you are working in the financial markets or something, you don't need financial education beyond a point. What fails you is not financial illiteracy, but lack of value education.

What you call as finance is mostly just arithmetic, right? So, it's not something that is extremely complex. So much is coming from there, so much is going there. Of course, it can get complicated when you go into derivative trading and stuff of that kind, but not many people anyway get there. In ordinary life, what brings you down is your greed, your ignorance towards life itself.

Q: Then what is the difference between financial literacy and the values that you were talking about?

AP: You want to buy a car, and you already have a car; you want to sell it. Now, it's one of the classical problems in finance management. Should you sell this one off? Should you buy a new one? Or should you simply lease a new one? And you develop scenarios, and in those scenarios you try to see which one is the best. And what is the criteria for an option being the best? It should give you the maximum positive financial return, right? So, that's how finance operates.

Value education is when you try to see whether you really need a car, or what is it within you that needs a car. Where did the basic urge to dispose of your existing one and buy a new one come from? And financial management does not go into that. It might turn out that you want a new car just because your brother-in-law has bought a new one. That's value education—to understand who you are and why exactly are you valuing a certain object. Once you have seen that an object is really valuable, after that comes the role of financial management. But you cannot have a good financial sense without any sense of values.

It might be, for example, financially better to buy something from the US rather than India. Value enquiry is about asking: Does that thing have value enough to be bought? What really is the value in that? Why must I go for it? And if I have to go for it, then I will, definitely; but do I need to? And if I feel very strongly about pursuing that object or that good or that goal, where did my desire come from? I didn't always have this desire; surely it sprang up someday from somewhere. What caused it? That's value literacy.

More than financial literacy, we need to be value literate. Otherwise, you can be financially very smart and yet a huge idiot. Huge idiot. Remember that the two big financial crises that we have faced in this century were both caused by top-end finance professionals. Very, very smart people, and they caused the economies of the entire world to sink, because they didn't have values, they didn't know what is valuable. So, their smarts were of no avail.

11.

FORGET PERFECTION, JUST DO THE BEST YOU CAN

Questioner: For the common mind there is suffering, the common kind of suffering, and pleasure, which is lower pleasure. Vedanta and the Upanishads exclaim that one has to pass through a higher suffering to enjoy higher pleasure. This seems to be a problem for most people, as taking on more suffering scares them.

Acharya Prashant: There is a way out. In your current level of existence, which you might call as a lower level, you have a certain capacity, a certain appetite to take suffering. It is not beyond you. Not a higher suffering but a lower suffering, suffering at your current level, which you may call a lower level.

The thing is, if you exercise even that level of suffering, it will bring to you a disproportionately higher pleasure. Once you taste that pleasure, then you realize that a formula has opened up, and then your willingness to take more discipline upon yourself increases, because now you have tasted the results.

At your particular level, you did the little you could. But the little you could do, the little you did do, was the maximum you could do at your particular level. The good news is that at any level, the maximum you do is sufficient. You are not demanded to do something beyond yourself; just do the maximum that is within your capacity. Good news is, you don't have to exceed your capacity. The challenge is, you have to do the maximum that is possible within your capacity.

Once you do the maximum within your capacity, you get results, and once you taste the results, your willingness to impose more discipline upon yourself increases. Now you know that a formula has opened up: "The more I exert myself, the better the results will be." Now you have been convinced with a proof—what is the proof? The results. The results have arrived.

“Now I know. Now I am unstoppable. Now I will go further and further and complete the distance.”

The trick is, at your current level, you have to do at least as much as is needed to show some results to you; otherwise you will be disappointed. The worst situation is of those who work but do not work hard enough even to get the minimum kinds of results possible. So, you have worked, you have exerted yourself, you have taken some suffering upon yourself, and yet you have not done enough to get even some kinds of preliminary results, so your scorecard stands at zero. Neither do you get anything, nor are you left with any motivation to do anything more.

So, if you are doing something, do at least as much as is needed to get some basic results, and those results will then egg you on. I repeat, the good news is: each of us, irrespective of how weak we are, has within his capacity to work as much as is needed to get the basic results, and the basic results will bring some trust in you, some inspiration in you; they will help you experience something that is totally new to you. And its taste will be so convincing that you will be inspired now to move ahead with deeper vigor.

So, there is that initial period when you are working and there will be no results; that is when you require faith and patience. Once the results start arriving, the results will keep spurring you on, and then, as I said, it is so formulaic. Now the ball has been set rolling; it will keep gaining momentum.

You don't have to take up very high kind of suffering; do only as much as you can—but please do as much as you can. On one hand I am saying, do only as much as you can, and in the same breath I am saying, please do as much as you can. But in neither of these cases am I saying, please do more than you can; that is not needed, because that cannot happen. How can you do more than you can?

That is the reason nobody else is to be blamed if you fail: because you are not even required to go beyond your capacity. It was within your capacity to succeed. If you fail, it was only because you didn't exercise your capacity. But if you scold someone for failing, he will say, “I did my best, and still I am being scolded!” Had you done your best, you would have obtained at least the basic results. If your scorecard always stands at zero, it is clear

proof that you are not doing even half of what you are capable of. That's why life punishes you.

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12.

FREEDOM FROM CHOICES—THE HIGHEST FREEDOM

Questioner (Q): You said that when there are options, choices, there can be no freedom. Earlier I used to think that I am free if I have choices, but Vedanta says that freedom can be only in choicelessness.

Acharya Prashant (AP): And isn't there great joy in being choiceless? You don't have to struggle; you don't have to be torn; you don't have to keep brooding over this and that. Life becomes so easy. "There might be a thousand things, but I do not see them. I see only the one thing that is Truth, that is related to my identity of being Truthful. I see just that." It makes life so easy.

Once you do not have the pull of a thousand choices acting upon you, think of the liberation you get. Else everything in the world is an opportunity, and nothing in the world suffices. Now, where does that put you? Everything is an opportunity, and no choice is good enough to be the final one—where does that put you? A rolling stone wandering from here to there—and wandering in frustration, in angst, because whatever you have done has not been good enough. Why has it not been good enough? Not because the choice was wrong but because the choice *existed*.

If you want to be sure of something being good for you, being right for you, just see whether there are competing choices. One mark of the real thing is that it affords no competition; you would have nothing else in mind. People may come and threaten you, somebody may come and lure you; you will say, "No, but this is the one way I know. I know not in the sense of habit but in the sense of realization. You are offering me a thousand diverse roads to travel; I don't even see them. They exist only for the ones who are tempted by them; I don't even see them."

Remember, even knowledge is not objective. If you have knowledge of something, it is because that thing first of all meant something to you;

otherwise, you won't even have knowledge. And knowledge can be such a burden, no? You know of so many things and they are all going around in the head.

"I don't even know. Why don't I know? Because I don't need to know. The deal is done. Why do I need to have so many options? Not that I am the proverbial frog in the well; just that I know very, very clearly." The frog in the well has no choices out of ignorance, and spiritual choicelessness is out of total realization.

"I have known, and I have reached a finality; therefore, I am not considering options at all." And that is the summit of life; that is where you want to reach; that is freedom from experiences. Otherwise, one will remain a sucker for experiences all his life. "I want to do this, next I want to do that, next I want to do that, this, this, this, this, this, this..."

Does the liberated man not do diverse and various things? He does, but he does not do them to satiate himself. He does everything *being* satiated, not *wanting* to be satiated. You get the difference? "Contentment I already have. Now, with my contentment I want to go there, reach there, attain this, discover that."

What is the difference, then? The difference is, if you are going to a place to attain contentment, then success and failure will weigh too heavily on you because just too much is at stake. You *need* to succeed; contentment is at stake. So much is at stake; contentment is everything: "I need to succeed." And if you need to succeed, you cannot play the game in freedom. When you are desperate for success, then you are frozen.

Whereas, when you are already content and then you want to achieve something, then you are actually taking it just like a game. And when you are taking it just like a game, there is so much joy, so much agility, so much maneuverability. There are just so many degrees of freedom that you get—why? Because now you are not afraid of failure. "I am not afraid of failure because I have already succeeded. I am entering the game and I am already a winner. I am a winner even before the game starts. Now I will play with abandon. Now there would be a certain freedom from botheration; I would be carefree."

And those who are too careful in life, they will know the importance of the word 'carefree'. How many of you are bogged down by care in your life? A lot of us, right? We will give our right hands to be carefree. Care is thought, care is concern; care is just too much weight on the top floor (*pointing at the head*). What happens to any structure that is top-heavy? Would you want to ride a top-heavy car? We live very top-heavy lives, no? The center of gravity is almost here (*pointing at the head*). When you are already contented, then the center of gravity is where it should be, not here but here (*moves his hand from the head to the chest*).

Many young people here, and the youth especially relishes choices. If you are being forced into doing something, then it's an improvement to have choices. You are being forced into marriage; your parents have seen a man for you and they are saying, "Go, wed this one. No choice! This one is final." In such a situation it is alright to ask for choice. But how about a situation where you have some forty-one boyfriends all at once? Are you related to even one of them? Is there any love anywhere?

Now you know what choicelessness means. Choices are good to have only when you are being forced into one loveless channel. When somebody is exercising his tyranny upon you and saying, "No, your will, your opinion doesn't matter, do what I say," in such a situation it is a better thing, an improvement to have choices.

But then, you, the youth of today, are hardly subjected to such behavior by circumstances or your family. I don't suppose today's parents chase their kids with an ultimatum of one final choice; parents don't do that. They hardly make decisions for their kids today, at least not in the urban areas. Instead, the malaise has appended itself: we have started believing that diversity in choices is a symbol or counter of our empowerment. We feel that the more choices we have, the more empowered we are. The truth is just the opposite.

Let choices exist externally. When they exist just outside of you, they are not even choices; they are just things. Internally, there should be not choices but clarity, and where there is clarity, you do not see too many things; you see just the one thing.

Therefore, a measure of your mental health is, do you keep weighing options? Do too many things keep going around in your head? Are you frequently indecisive about what to pick? One mark of the realized man is, his decisions come in a flash, once he has all the data that is. If decisions require data, obviously he will take time to gather the data. Once the facts are in front of him, the decision does not take time; he does not need to appoint an inner committee to ponder. He will ask for data, and the data is there, and he says, “This (*makes a gesture indicating picking an option*), done” because he is not being internally ruled by competing desires. If he is desirous, he is desirous of just the Truth. He does not have multiple desires in ten different directions.

Remember, each of the choices that appeal to you correspond to a particular desire within you. Let’s say I like him, him, and him (*pointing at various listeners in the audience*), and he is saying, “Well, it’s my birthday today, let’s spend the evening together”; the other one is saying, “I’m down today, come and console me”; the third one is saying, “I got some fantastic things, there is this special bundle of books. Come, let’s read together.” They are all related to me through competing desires. There is the desire within me to be a big brother to someone, there is a desire within me to be knowledgeable, there is a desire within me to have fun, and none of these three desires are desire for the Truth.

I am fragmented within, and the thousand parts within me become the thousand choices outside of me. Now, what happens? The desire for fun says, “There is the birthday party. Go there!” So, this choice becomes appealing. Do you see why this choice matters to me? Because I have a particular desire that corresponds to this choice; I have the desire for fun. I have the desire to gain knowledge, so this fellow who says, “Come, let’s read together” becomes significant to me. And I have the desire to be moralistic, to be big-brotherly, to have the upper hand in the emotional sense, so this option, this choice becomes meaningful to me. He is saying, “Oh, I am down. Please come, your company will lift my mood,” and it’s a great opportunity to prove that I can be a good counselor, that I know emotion-management better than this chap.

A thousand things are important to us because we are a thousand people inside; we are not one. And being a thousand inside, having a crowd within

is such a pain, is it not? You are nowhere. None of those thousand is you actually, and each of those thousand has a certain inclination: one of them wants dosa, the other one wants to travel to Mars. Now, how do these two become compatible? One is always crying, “Dosa! Dosa with spicy sambar!” The next one is thinking of cryogenic engines. Now, how does the cryogenic engine find any relationship with sambar?

One within you is a political animal deeply interested in politics; one within you is a gardener; one loves verses and bhajans from saints. Now, how is it possible that you cultivate both at the same time, political cunningness and saintly innocence? But we manage to do that, don’t we? When you are first sitting here, and it’s the fifth day today, and in between a lot of us would have found time to exercise our political imagination—so many things are happening in politics every day—and we go back having read the Upanishads and see what the prime minister is doing and how he is being encircled by the opposition and such things. How do we manage to have these two concurrently?

I am not saying one of them has to be dropped; I am saying all the relationships that we have with the world must come from a single center. Your political opinion has to have a consonance with your Upanishadic knowledge; else you are making them sit in two different rooms in your psyche and this fragmentation will not let you breathe; you will be sitting here thinking of something else.

With one choice your energy is concentrated. And when your mind has so many options to feast on, all your energy is squandered on the feast. The ego is happy, and life is sad. The ego is happy that, you know, “I have this, I have that; I am so very well networked. If something bad happens to me, I have so many people to seek help from. I am a professional networker. Every day I wish happy birthday to at least three people. So, if something bad happens to me, help can potentially come from so many places.”

The thing is, when you are in such a situation, it’s already a bad thing happening to you. You are preparing for something bad happening to you by having this network of choices, but having this network of choices is already a bad thing happening to you. I do not know whether any of those contacts would be of help in the time of need—they might be, they might

not be, I don't know—but what I know for sure is that such a mind cannot be at peace, a mind that is rushing after security through diversity.

The rules of the inner world are very different from that of the outer world. In the outer world you say, “Don't put all your eggs in one basket. Hedge your bets. Diversify your portfolio”; that's what you say in the outer world. In the inner world it's just the opposite: there should be one and the one and the one, and you have to be *absolutely* invested in it, hundred percent investment in just the one. Inside, if you diversify your portfolio, you are ruined.

Put all your inner capital into Truth incorporated. Externally, you will then have all the freedom to invest at whatever place you like, and then you will always also have the guts to invest in outrageous ventures because you will not be afraid of loss. And when you are investing in outrageous ventures, miracles can happen. You may also lose whatever you have invested, but then you are not afraid of losing. You are not even dying to get miracles. It's just that it is now seriously good fun. You can play. Think of it.

Winning and losing come much later. The tragedy is that most of us cannot even play. Our problem is not that we lose so much; our problem is that we do not even play. What's worse, losing or not even playing? When you prepare so much to play, you cannot play. When you have the apparatus put meticulously in preparation of the play, to secure the play, then you cannot play; then all that you are doing is the arrangement.

“I am arranging, and I am arranging with such precision. All my energy has gone into the arrangement; the real thing never happens. I have the security agencies in place, forty thousand fire extinguishers I have brought here; everything I have done to prepare for the party. I have informed the police, there is all the security and the bandobast, five different agencies are videographing the event, I went around and commissioned twenty different caterers—so much choice! Twenty different caterers I commissioned, I really spent a lot of time on it. I spent my entire life commissioning the security agencies, the photographer, the videographer, the caterer, the event manager. I forgot one little thing—the party.”

Everything has been neatly arranged for the party. And in making so many arrangements...

“I wanted to have backups, you know. If plan A fails, B has to be there, then C, then D. After Z, there is ZA, ZB, ZC...”

So, all those backups and choices and options, they all have to be in place. When you care for it so much, then that’s the only thing that you care for, and then care is what you live for; party is gone. Everything is in place—except the party. Forty thousand fire extinguishers—and no fire! One thousand security guards, but with nothing precious enough to secure. Hurts, no?

You build a mansion and it is fiercely guarded. The only little problem is that in the mansion there is nothing worthy of being secured or guarded. So, the guards are all top-class—we will call them commandos. It’s just that it’s a void inside. What are you securing?

“But no, I have made all the arrangements, you see. Even if an intruder breaches the first ring of security, then there is a second ring, and then there is this, then there is this, and then there is this automated alarm that goes off and para-commandos from Jupiter land straightaway!”

So, layers, buffers, backups, options—all defending nothing. Nothing at all. Like a jewelry case being used to deliver trash. It had layers of packaging!

That’s the thing with choices. You have so many choices but the chooser is in such a bad state. What do you want to care more for, the choices or the chooser? Care for the chooser. The choices will fall in place. Who is the chooser? We are the chooser.

Care for who you are within. All choices are to *you*. All choices are for *you*. You change, and the choices that are visible to you will change. So many things that used to present themselves will no more present themselves; you will just forget that choice. If something does not appeal to you, would you still call it a choice? It’s not even an option; it’s just a thing now because it doesn’t appeal. Why doesn’t it appeal anymore? Because I am no more the one who I was.

Care for the chooser. With the chooser remaining the same, having a plethora of choices is just self-deception. If you remain the same, none of your choices are going to help you. And we cultivate so many choices in the hope that at least one of them will be of some help. None of those choices

will help you because you are looking in the wrong direction, you are looking at things. You have to look at the chooser, at yourself.

Q: I am new to spirituality and I don't know how I should proceed. I have started courses at my college which I am not very certain about. I feel that there was no clarity in choosing those courses, but now I am stuck with them. You have said that our real identity is *atīṣṭa caitanya*, unfulfilled consciousness. How to understand this statement correctly in my situation?

AP: That's what we are—the thirsty, desperate consciousness. When you say, "What should I do?" you have to ask, "What do I want? What is it that will be good for me? What must I want?" And the thing that is worthy of being wanted is the thing to do.

So, what do you want? Rather, what is worthy of being wanted? Put efforts towards identifying it. What is it that is not false, or at least not as false as the other things in life? Identify what is the least false of all, and for the while go with it. And then keep thinking, keep watching, keep observing, and you will come upon something that is even more true; then go for that. That's the way of life: keep rejecting what is the lowest about you.

It's like this. Put everything in your life in a descending order of value. See what all is present in your life—what is present in your life? Whatever you think of, whatever is in your mind, that is said to be in your life, even if it is not physically there. So, let's say there are a hundred things in your life. Begin with the bottom five. See that you are associated with them for no good reason. See that you are cultivating false hopes from those things. Those things in themselves might not be bad at all. Remember, we said that dropping the false is not about dropping that particular object, or at least not despising that particular object. Even if you have to let go of that object, you let go of that object admitting that it was your fault to have associated with that object in the first place.

So, identify the bottom five, let go of them, and that will give you the strength to do the same with the next five, and also that will create vacancy for five or ten better things to arrive in life. This is the way of continuous progress—continuous, incremental, never-ending. Always keep space for correction. It doesn't matter how you chose the course you are doing. Forget the past. Today, ask yourself, "What is it that I want from life? Will I

get it through this? Maybe there are things I won't get through this, maybe there are certain important things I will definitely get through this."

So, know fully well who you are. You are a discontented consciousness. Be it the choice of a garment, or the choice of an academic course, the choice of a car to ride, the choice of a question to ask—all these things should be governed by who you are.

I am dissatisfied, I want to be satisfied. The jacket that I will wear should come from that perspective. It should not be a random decision, because all that I want is satisfaction—satisfaction not of the flimsy kind, but satisfaction of my consciousness. So, whether I am choosing a camera to buy, or a chair to buy, or choosing a place to visit, the criteria will remain the same and one—what is the criteria? Will it bring contentment to my consciousness?

So, on this criteria evaluate the choice of your academic course. All else is secondary.

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13.

FIGHT HARD AND FORGET THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN VICTORY AND DEFEAT

Questioner (Q): Sir, in a lot of your talks you redirect our focus towards ourselves. As living beings, all of us seek contentment and happiness. So, my question to you is, how can one be content without being complacent? How does one achieve that?

Acharya Prashant (AP): See, complacency can be there only when you have just not bothered to enquire into the facts of your life. Otherwise, it is impossible to be smug and ultra-confident about your state. None of us, factually, are in a great state internally. It is an unfortunate fact, but a fact is a fact.

So, there is sickness, dissatisfaction, incompleteness, psychosis, anxiety, fear. And when the placement season comes, then we are jittery, and if the next fellow gets a higher pay package, then we become jealous. We know all these things are there, and knowing all these things, if we still certify ourselves to be internally healthy, then there is something very wrong with our compass of honesty. Either that, or we are so afraid that we just don't even want to enquire within.

“Am I okay? Why did I just start trembling? I am standing in front of that interview room—let's say it is a day-zero company—and I suddenly find myself weak in the knees and shaking in my trousers. Why is that happening?” And it is a very real happening; it is actually physical. You can't even say that it was inside, so you didn't see; it is there in the body, you can't deny its presence. But having seen all that, if we still want to insist that we are happy, then there is a great problem.

Now, coming to contentment. Contentment is the very last thing. At your stage in life, as a young person, you should have a lot of dissatisfaction—a lot of dissatisfaction—because if you settle at the point you already are

inwardly, outwardly, within, without, then you would be settling at a very suboptimal point. Your potential is far higher. So, there is no point talking of contentment at this age because being what we are, at this age and stage, we don't even know what contentment is; we are bound to misinterpret it.

So, leave contentment for a later stage. At this point, rebel and rise. See what confines you and don't accept it; fight it out, and don't bother too much for the result. If you have given a good fight, then the word 'contentment' can probably kick in, in the sense that "I did the utmost I could. Beyond this, it was not possible for me to do anything. Honestly, I say that there is nothing that I held back; I gave the fight more than what I had." Now you can probably be contented—contented not in the sense that the fight is over, but contented in the sense that now you are ready for the next and bigger fight.

Final contentment is final deliverance; it is liberation, actually. So, do not talk of that. When I talk to young people, it is much more advisable that they look at things and challenge them, question them. Believe me, and you need not actually believe me because you see this thing with your own eyes: much in the world today needs to be challenged and demolished. Just do not be easily satisfied.

Q: But we are living in a very goal-oriented, outcome-driven world. How does one achieve that detachment of giving one's best while not being focused on the result?

AP: No, it is not detachment really; I would say you have to be in love with your war, your action. If you are challenging something, if you have taken up an enormous project, be in love with it. I am not talking of detachment; I am talking of love here. Be in love with your work and give it just everything that you have. For that you would, first of all, require the work to be that enormous and that loveable.

In anything that you enter, in anything that you take up, the quality of the relationship must be so high that you are encouraged, that you are left choiceless in attending to it. You cannot hold yourself back. You will not say, "Now it is 6 p.m., so I must get up from my seat and leave" or that, "In this task, I was supposed to contribute only so much and no more." Give it all that you have. And once you have given it all that you have, you will

find that you will be left with very little time, space, or energy to bother about the result.

See, bothering about the result is an energy-intensive affair, is it not? You may take three hours just preparing for an exam, and then you may keep worrying about the result for thirty days. Worrying, brooding, and thinking about the result—all this consumes a lot of our lives. Now, if you are worrying about the outcome, I would say, why do you have spare time at all? Why has this time, firstly, not been utilized in the action itself? And if you say, “Well, the deed is done, now I have spare time,” I will say, what about the next and the higher deed? Why are you squandering away even one moment of this precious but limited life? How come you have the time?

So, when one is madly in love, when one is intensely in action, then the outcome becomes immaterial. Not because one is indifferent or detached; no, it is not a case of detachment; it is a case of intense love. “I gave everything that I had; now it is difficult to differentiate between defeat and victory.” You could say the one who could differentiate between these two, the one who could be affected by the outcome is left with nothing to be affected with; he held back nothing. He gave everything that he/she had.

Think of a six-hour Wimbledon final, or a seven-hour match—we have had matches like that. The loser, believe me, does not really regret that match. I have read of Grand Slam champions who, when asked about their most unforgettable match, would not talk about one of their Grand Slam finals or semifinals; they would talk about one match that they fought and lost. Now, that is one match that they cannot forget. That is one match that brought life to them as never before, because that was the match that drained everything out of them. And finally, when the winning shot was played, neither side could differentiate between victory and defeat.

As a spectator, you would mind who held the trophy, and only one of the two parties is now carrying the trophy, so you would say, “Oh well, Nadal won and Federer lost.” But ask them, who have just played a five-setter that has extended up to six hours or seven hours; they will say, “Well, this is my most unforgettable match. I do not remember who won or who lost—that is something I won’t remember. But the match I can’t forget.”

That's the way to live life. Live so intensely that in the end you are left with no energy to be concerned with the result. And that does not mean that you will necessarily meet defeat; sometimes there is victory, sometimes there is defeat, but that is not the point. The point is how you have played the game.

Play it with all your might; it raises you like anything. It raises you to enter a bigger game, a higher game—and that's the game.

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14.

QUALITY LIVING: A COMPREHENSIVE GUIDE TO SUCCESS

Questioner (Q): How to lead a quality life in this materialistic world? What should be our aim when it comes to success, and what should we do to attain a higher level?

Acharya Prashant (AP): You see, we have a concept of success. And there are certain things entailed in the concept—a certain amount of money, a certain social prestige, a certain excellence in one's chosen field of work, and all that comes. But it is quite possible that all that may be there and one is still discontented. It is because all that which we have achieved is within our self-defined concept of success; one has to go beyond it.

Obviously, if our concept of success includes four things, and all those four things have been ticked against and still there is dissatisfaction, it means the concept is not quite working. One has to then go beyond it; then one has to aim for something higher than success. Then one has to ask: What is it that matters more than success?

One sees that all the success that one has tried to obtain has been primarily for himself. You say, *your* educational qualification; you say, *your* love life; you say, *your* son; you say, *your* profession. So, success is in general defined with the 'me' at the center. "I did this for myself. I did this for myself and I succeeded." And there are a lot of things that one does for himself and succeeds and is yet not satisfied.

That hints again and again at the failure of the conceptual framework itself. Maybe one needs actions that are not directed towards the fulfillment of the 'me'. The 'me' has been greatly fulfilled. The 'me' has been appeased a lot already. All that this little 'me' kept demanding has been provided to it; at least most of what has been demanded has been served. And still the 'me' keeps clamoring; it is still not satisfied.

Maybe the way out is to look beyond the 'me'. Maybe the way out is to work for a cause that does not include the 'me'.

"I did well in my practice. I did well in my love life. I did well in my social interactions. I did well in my studies. I did well in doing whatever I wanted to do—maybe I am a mountain climber, maybe I am a deep sea diver. Whatever I am, I am for myself. Now, can I be bigger and broader than that? Can I be something without being much for myself? Can my actions be directed towards others? Can service now enter my life? There is a lot of success which has been self-centered. Can I now move on to service?"

Service will probably not fulfill this restless 'I', but service would enable you to forget this restless 'I'. That is beyondness—not quite the fulfillment of the little 'I', but a certain forgetfulness towards the little 'I'. You say that you are serving a cause bigger than yourself, or you are serving others; therefore there is no time nor opportunity to keep wondering whether your own demands have been met.

One is restless, one is restless, one is restless, and then one starts dedicating himself to something bigger, something larger. And the bigger cause consumes so much attention, time, energy, that one is left with no space to complain or wonder whether one is internally fulfilled.

You say, "Even if I remain unfulfilled, it is a small matter. I might be happy, I might be sad—the work I have taken up is bigger than my little happiness and sadness. It does not quite matter how I am feeling. I am unfulfilled? Oh, probably I am; but I just forgot that." This is beyondness. "Am I unfulfilled? Probably I still am, but who cares? I have better things to take care of." This is fulfillment.

When thoughts of your personal success stop mattering to you, when you say, "There is something more important than my personal success," then you have really succeeded.

Q: So, it has to be bigger?

AP: It has to be so big that you forget about your failures, your happiness, your sadness. Somebody comes and tells you, "But you are sad!" and you say, "Oh! Am I sad? I just forgot that."

Somebody comes and tells you, “You have not had meals since the last thirty-six hours.” You say, “Oh! Am I hungry? I just forgot that. I was so engrossed in something large, in something meaningful that I totally forgot my personal appetite; it just vanished. Not that it does not exist; now that you are reminding me that I have not had food, I see that I have not had food. Now, in fact, I am also feeling hungry. Now that you have reminded me, I have also started feeling hungry. But for the last thirty-six hours, hunger didn’t matter. I didn’t even know that I was hungry. All my attention was dedicated towards something broader, larger.” That has to be there.

And this is the only way out, especially for people who have achieved a certain level of worldly attainment. You know, people who have no worldly attainment at all, they keep saying, “But we need to prove ourselves in the world; we need to get a job, we need to earn some money, we need to get a wife, we need to have a decent family,” and they keep insisting that this is what would fulfill them.

But then there are those who already have all those things, who already have a certain level of financial attainment, social attainment, intellectual attainment, familial attainment, and they are still not satisfied. Then the only thing that can fulfill them is forgetfulness.

Q: You might not have expectations from others, but others have expectations from you.

AP: When you say others have expectations from you, the circle of these others, the set of these others is very, very limited and ‘me’-centric, is it not? You do not really care about the expectations that, let’s say, the entire humanity has from you.

It is bitterly cold and a dog is outside your doorsteps. You do not wonder about the expectations that that dog might be having. It is only the expectations of a particular four people that matter to you—four people. And who are these four people? The ones with whom you have the bond of ‘me’, ‘mine’, ‘my’.

If you have to cater to expectations, then why not cater to the expectations of an entire nation, or the entire world, or the entire animal kingdom? Entire species are vanishing every day; don’t they expect you to help them? So, answer their expectations.

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15.

SIR, ARE YOU SUCCESSFUL?

Questioner: People have different ways of defining success for themselves, like influence, happiness, fame, name, etc. So, when did you start considering yourself successful? How do you define it for yourself?

Acharya Prashant: I don't consider myself a success even today. So, your question is founded on an assumption when you say that when in the past did I start considering myself a success; you are assuming that at some point I did or currently I do. No, I don't.

I don't think there is any end point called success. As long as one is alive, there is more and more to be done continuously. One can declare herself successful only if the target is too small, too limited. And then you can get close to the target or win it and say that you are successful, but that kind of declaration means nothing. One is then just fooling, pampering himself; does not mean much.

There can be milestones along the way. As you move, you can probably see that you are going past a few important points, and even those points are important only relatively, right? Relative to where you currently stand, you might find that a few milestones mean much to you. But in the overall sense, in the absolute perspective, hardly anything that you have gone past makes much significance or holds too much of a meaning, right?

So, one has to continuously keep moving. This notion of becoming successful, this idea that by reaching a particular point or by having a certain accomplishment one can declare himself as successful, is not very mature and is also dangerous, because it limits you. It tells you that there are certain things to be had, and more or less those things are universal, right? You want to have an educational degree, you want to have a job, you want to have money, you want to have a settled kind of life, and you want to be regarded highly in the society; and if you have all these things then you start calling yourself successful.

This is a limiting, rather debilitating idea. It will not allow you to move beyond these things that we just listed. And even among these things, you know what it is that counts in the common idea of success? Money. Because if you have money, prestige can be bought. If you have money, much under the sun can be bought. So, primarily the idea of success as it is prevalent in the youth today and is being aggressively sold in the market is about having money. If you have enough money, you can call yourself successful.

No, that is not a valid idea, right? Because you have to look at yourself and ask yourself, “Who am I? Why am I born? Why do I exist at all? Is there complete fulfillment? Isn’t there more that needs to be done? Isn’t the fire still burning?” There are frontiers after frontiers, there are skies beyond skies. How can you stop at some place and just abruptly, randomly, arbitrarily call yourself successful? What I have seen from my little experience, and when I look at my peers and my batchmates, is that the moment you call yourself successful, you start stagnating, because success is like a destination, no?

The idea that we have been sold is that you move to attain success. Extended logically, then it means that success is the end of all movement. If one moves, that is if one works to attain success, if that is the idea, then success will be the end of all movement, right?—the destination. And if you reach the destination, then what are you still traveling for? If the train has reached its destination, you are supposed to deboard, aren’t you? And if you don’t get down on your own, you are thrown out. That’s the meaning of success—deboard, finished, game up.

Why do you want to finish the game so early, too early? Life is anyway short; you can never have too much of it. And on top of it, you want to end it inwardly at the age of thirty, thirty-five or forty? That doesn’t make sense, right?

So, Vedanta says: *Charaiveti, charaiveti*—continuously keep moving. Don’t fool yourself by declaring yourself as arrived. Don’t tell yourself that you have reached any important position. Don’t inflate yourself. Don’t become a big one or a successful one in your own eyes. Retain that humility and don’t douse the fire. Because that’s the fact. Nobody is fully liberated as long as he or she is alive, which means that the mission still remains

unfulfilled. If you are breathing, if you are still breathing, then the mission remains on till your last breath. You are somebody who must keep working, walking, moving.

So, first thing I would advise: know what is it in life that you must keep striving for, working towards, and then endlessly work in that direction. Let there be a direction but never a destination.

So, you know the broad direction in which you have to move, and the movement has to be immense, endless, infinite. One moves in the direction of liberation without ever arriving. That's something that does not quite please the ego, because the ego likes to arrive; it likes to settle matters. It likes to say, "The end, the matter stands concluded." Don't fall in that trap.

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16.

THE SUCCESS STORIES OF AMBITIOUS PEOPLE—BE CAREFUL!

Questioner (Q): My question is about ambition. What is ambition, and how can you create it within yourself? How to create such a force within that will help you tackle all the failures and obstacles in life? When we hear the so-called success stories of successful people, we find that they had a lot of pitfalls in their life, they had a lot of hurdles that they faced, but it was ambition that helped them reach where they are. So, how do you develop that force within?

Acharya Prashant (AP): We will take that. It's a very, very important question; it's a life-changing question. You know, you have your own life to live, first of all, and nobody can be fulfilled reaching a place somebody else has reached. You are born differently. What fulfills one cannot fulfill the other. What's more, you do not even know whether the other is fulfilled.

You have somebody in front of you who is touting himself as a success story. "I am a success story. I had ambitions, and fueled by ambition, I braved all the challenges in life, and then I have reached this particular place, so I am a superstar. Come on, follow me. I present myself as a role model."

How do you know, first of all, that he has really reached any place of any worth? He is showing you what he needs to show you. The video that you are watching is a heavily curated and edited one. Don't you know that? All kinds of filters and edits; so much has been put into it. The video I am talking of is the person's life story. How do you know how he is internally? And if all your role models have indeed reached worthy places, why do you hear of so many cases of suicides among those people? Why? And when they die by suicide, it makes big news. It makes big news precisely because so many people considered them their role models, right?

Now, if he was really worthy of being a role model, why suicide? Why so many other things? Why tax evasion? Why so many other kinds of crimes? He was a role model charged of murder, black money, money laundering, hawala, drug abuse, rape, illicit dealings. I am not alleging that all those you consider role models indulge in these things. I am asking you, what do you know of his inner life? Can you? Being a celebrity, will he allow the inner details to ever emerge out? He is living off his reputation. His reputation is his earning. Will he allow his reputation to be tainted? Then how can you be so ignorant, so gullible that you watch a video or read a story and think of it as true? Did you publish that video? Who published that video? Come on. He published that video. So, he is showing you what he wants to show you. He is doing what he wants to do. Why do you have to believe in what he is doing?

Get that thing off your mind. When something fancy comes in front of you on the screen or somewhere, you just feel compelled, and the visuals and the audios and the narrative, that just overpowers you, does it not? The eyes, they are gone; they are no more yours. The screen has captivated the eyes; the narrative has enchanted the mind. It's all gone. You are enslaved. And can you question the screen? Can you pause the video and say, "Well, I have a question to ask"? Can you do that? You can't. Even if that fellow is speaking live, chances are he will not accept live questions. Even if he does accept a live question, chances are he will not tolerate cross-questioning; he will not allow the real thing to emerge.

So, there is no need, as young people, for you all, to just fall for the stories. They are stories. They are very, very carefully written stories. Every single aspect of that story is minutely manufactured before the story is released.

Now, ambition. Basically desire, right? Small desire, you do not call it ambition. When the desire is big enough, you start calling it an ambition, right? You want a glass of water, a little tumbler; you would say, "I want it." You want a bigger jug; you probably call it a desire. You want an entire tank; that's an ambition. What has changed? Is there a fundamental difference? You want a little plot of land for yourself; you call it a desire. You want to win over an entire country, which itself is a plot of land, a bigger plot of land; you call it...?

Q: Desire.

AP: So, that's desire, simple desire. And you know where all desires come from? Your animalistic, biological conditioning.

Have you seen dogs fight over their territories? Have you seen how one dog gets bitterly furious when another dog encroaches over its territory? And have you seen how they mark their territories? They just raise one leg, and the stuff that they do is actually a territory marker that's to indicate to the other dogs: "This is the border, the international line. Don't breach into my sovereignty!" But then a great king captures ten lakh square kilometers, and you say, "Oh, the Great! *Mahaan!*" He is doing what dogs have always done—capturing territory. That's ambition—amplifying your animal nature. That's what. What do ambitious people want? Please, tell me. More and more of the material, right? That's what animals also want. What's there in that?

You have a life to live. You are very young. Can you work for something rather worthy? Can your energy come from love rather than ambition? And when you are very ambitious, obviously that inspires energy within, right? If you have desire for something, you feel energized. Have you seen that? And when you are ambitious, you feel all the more energized. It's just that all that energy is very cyclical: one moment you feel motivated, the other moment you feel demotivated, and then you run towards some motivation pill.

But anyway, a lot of energy comes from ambition. If you are ambitious, you will find spurts in energy. Can you live in the energy that comes from love? That's the question. Ambition says, "I will be fulfilled when I achieve that." Can you spend your life doing something that you do in fulfillment itself rather than targeting an imaginary fulfillment twenty years later? "I am starting up. Here is my new venture. Two years, it will break even, if I am lucky. Six years later, IPO, and then two years after that I will exit. And when I exit, I will have lots of money and sell off my shares, and then I will be fulfilled." Is it possible instead to choose something to do that keeps you fulfilled all the time? That's what I am talking of as energy of love. Is it possible?

You have to get into that question. There are no easy answers. But that's a question that you must ask yourself. These are the golden years of your life, right? Do you want to spend these years doing something you cannot even

tolerate doing but still continue doing because you feel desirous of the future? Do you want to do that?

Think of your courses. How many courses have you in a semester? Six? Nobody loves all the six courses, at least I never did. How do you live through the courses you don't love? It was very difficult for me; I don't know if that's easy for you. Don't you have an attendance requirement or something? No? Okay. Lucky! Seventy-five percent attendance requirement, and seventy-five percent means seventy-five percent. Living through the semester was not an easy job, because it's just impossible to appreciate all the courses that came your way. But that was a requirement.

Once you are out of the campus, there are no requirements, there is freedom. Do you want to spend your life—let's say the next five years, ten years—as if you are enrolled in a course you are just waiting to come to an end? “Let the semester end; let me be relieved of this particular course, even if with a C or D grade.” That's how most people spend their lives. They just have no relationship with the work they are doing. All that they have is ambition, desires; no love.

Tell me, if you love your work, would you ever think of selling off your company? But your role models, they are all serial entrepreneurs, are they not? If you really love what you have created, what you have brought up, would you simply sell it off? Would you do that? Please. Is there any love in what they are doing? I am asking you. There is just opportunism, and that opportunism gets them money. But what does money get you?

That's not the way to live; that just leaves you very, very poor within. And that's what matters. And you become a curse not only to yourself but a bane to entire humanity, because you earned a lot of money, and that lot of money is now in the hands of a foolish person. So, what will that foolish man do with that money? Not just consume—destroy. He will fund all the wrong kinds of things. He will buy a living enterprise and turn it dead. Do you have a recent example?

That's what happens when a foolish man gets to have a lot of money—the entire planet is destroyed. And because money can give you a lot of reach, all your nonsensical concepts will become household things. You will start saying, “Well, climate change is not a problem at all. Well, the Earth

actually needs more kids. Come on, go reproduce! What if the Earth is burned to ashes? We will go and colonize another planet.”

Ambition is a very stale thing. It's a dead thing. Do not forget where it comes from; it comes from your past in the jungle. You are conditioned to be desirous, and social forces just encourage you to be even more desirous of the same things that you have been wanting since a million years. The same things.

Let's do something new, as young people. Or do you want to live the same life that your ancestors in the jungle were living? The monkey wanted a fruit, you want an orchard—is that a fundamentally different thing? Please. They were running after female monkeys then, and even today you are running after the female monkey, maybe in a Ferrari. And the female monkey was attracted towards the alpha monkey then; even today the female monkey is attracted towards the alpha monkey. Who is the alpha monkey today? The one with the Ferrari and the money. It's all so monkeyish. Can we live fresh lives, new lives? Or do you want to continue that same animalistic tradition?

Q: No. The new one.

AP: Then tell yourself that you are free to not believe, to not be influenced. Freedom must be your most important value. The world wants to steal away the most important thing that you have, which is freedom of mind, liberty of consciousness. Do not allow the world to do that. And the world is not just outside of you; it is also inside of you. Your own thoughts and emotions—be very cautious of them. They are not yours; they belong to the world. They belong to this body, and this body belongs to the world. This body is a heavily conditioned body; this brain is a part of this body and is equally heavily conditioned.

So, if an emotion arises in the brain or a thought wave is there, do not just quickly accept it or identify with it. Know that it is coming from the jungle, or it is coming from the marketplace. “It is not mine. So, I will be cautious. It is not mine. These emotions are not mine. Even the dog has these emotions. How can these emotions be mine?” Look at dogs and cats; that will tell you who you are. All of us are just dogs and cats. There is hardly anything in human life that does not belong to the life of a dog or a cat.

Then how can this life be ours? Which means that no life has been given to us by our physical or social tradition; they do not give us any life. Life has to be created afresh. You have to write a new script of your own. The old script is not yours; it's a borrowed thing, and it's a very bad and dangerous thing. Do not live by that script.

Ask yourself these basic questions. Are you doing anything that is fundamentally different from what your grandparents were doing?—fundamentally different, not just superficially. You want money, your grandpa also wanted money—how are you different? What's new? He also wanted more money compared to somebody else. What's new?

We are not saying that newness is not possible, it is definitely possible; definitely a new life can be lived, definitely. But not if you do not discard the old life. And you cannot discard it if you do not know that it is old. We keep thinking of the old as the new. We keep thinking of all the old stuff as brand new. “Oh, I have fallen in love. I am the first man in the world to fall in love!” It is happening all over the place, son. “I have fallen in love for the nth time in life, not the first time!” What's new? Can we have something new?

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17.

DOES SELF-IMPROVEMENT LEAD TO WORLDLY SUCCESS?

Questioner (Q): Does self-improvement lead to worldly success?

Acharya Prashant (AP): Self, the same self that you are seeking to improve and are thereby admitting to be in need of improvement and therefore currently flawed, is the one that determines your ideal of success. Please understand. From where does your thought or ideal of success come? From the self. And at the same time you are saying you want self-improvement, which means your self is yet not fit enough to determine targets for you.

It's like going to the GPS repair shop because you know that your GPS system is faulty and using your faulty GPS to know the route to the GPS shop. Who is giving you your concept of success? The self. And this self, you are admitting, is in need of improvement; which means that even your concept of success is faulty.

So, self-improvement will not give you success. If you see that the self is misplaced or flawed, then self-improvement *itself* is success. Because that's the most fundamental failure; that's the mother of all failures. Who determines your success or failure? The self, meaning the little ego. The little ego is the one that sets your targets. The little ego is the one who then certifies whether you have succeeded or failed. Who does all these things? The little self. So, are your successes really successes? They are not.

Your GPS might be telling you that you have reached Taj Mahal. According to GPS, "Success! Taj Mahal—arrived!" And you look up and what do you find? "Uh... Is this Taj Mahal?" But the GPS is yelling, "Success! Success!" Ego is saying, "Success! Success!" And life and facts are telling you, "Disaster! Disaster!" Similarly, the GPS might tell you that Taj Mahal is still a hundred miles away, and you look up and what do you find? You are right in front of the Taj Mahal.

So, the successes that the little self certifies are not successes at all. The failures that the little self cries about are not failures at all. Therefore, the only failure is to live by a faulty GPS. Because if you are living by a faulty GPS, not one but all your destinations will be wrong. So, which is the only success then? Better fix the GPS.

Self-improvement will not beget success. Self-improvement *is* success. If the self has corrected itself, then whatever it does would now be right, and that is success.

Q: And this is where spirituality comes in, right? Correction of the self happens when it comes to know that it is inherently flawed and...

AP: And it is a super stupid thing to know that your GPS is faulty but to keep driving according to it. Once you know that your ego, your tendencies, your thoughts are all haywire, and if you still support them and live by them, then it's not merely stupid.

This is *Adhyatma Upanishad*, Verse 4.

“The mind of the yogi perishes as he stays without intermission in the Self alone, knowing through reasoning, listening and experience that one is the Self of all beings.”

Q: Knowing, listening and experience?

AP: Knowing, listening and experience. Through all the faculties, and also through the Self itself. The verse says, “The mind of the yogi perishes as, using all his powers and faculties, he knows that he is the Self of all things.” The verse says, “He lives in his great Truth, in the Self, without a break, without an intermission.”

The mind wanders only as long as it seeks different things, and differences are infinite. If you seek different things, then you have an infinite number of things to seek, because differences define the universe. Our universe is made up of differences, objects. The yogi is the one who has come to a union; the two have become one. The wandering mind is now not interested in differences; the wandering mind has realized that even in the differences it was actually seeking the One. Why then seek the One in the many? Why not directly be with the One? That is Yoga.

That's the situation of the yogi. He goes directly to what he wants. He does not seek jewels at the grocer's shop. He is not looking for oranges in an apple orchard. He knows what he wants, and he knows where it cannot be obtained. So he is not stupidly wandering anymore. He has seen that behind all his desires lies just one fundamental desire: that fundamental desire is called salvation, fulfillment, union, dissolution into the Beloved, surrender. Names are many.

Not only has he seen that there is only one ultimate desire behind all desires—he has also seen that if he keeps catering to multiple desires, the one fundamental desire will remain unfulfilled. All desires are of the One alone. But if you keep going after miscellaneous desires, then the one desire will remain unmet. That's what his honesty, efforts, dedication, listening, experience and meditation have brought him to see.

So, he is smart now, very smart. He says, “Why should I be in the journey when I can directly be at the destination?” He stays at the destination without a gap, without intermission. Chill!

Q: What's the connection between spirituality and transcendentalism?

AP: All spirituality is to transcend. In fact, there is no word called ‘transcendence’ sans spirituality. Without spirituality there is only the world and thoughts and feelings—objects, images, things, perceptions, men, women, animals, stones, sands, rivers. Three-dimensional movie, all that it can contain. If there is one gift that the East has given to the world, it is the very word ‘transcendence’. Even the idea of transcendence liberates to a great extent. Because if you do not even have the idea of *mukti* – transcendence is *mukti*—if you do not even have the idea of transcendence, then all other ideas remain very big on you.

Strictly speaking, transcendence would mean going beyond—*ullaṅghana* (jumping over), *atikramaṇa* (stepping over), *laṅghajana* (leaping over)—or disappearance, *samādhi*. In the material world there is nothing called the beyond. In the material world, beyond the material there is just more material; beyond ideas there are just more ideas; beyond experience, more experience; beyond the mind, more mind; beyond imaginations, more imaginations.

Transcendence is what brings another dimension to you. That other dimension is also what is called the God dimension. You cannot transcend the material to move into more material; you transcend the material, and that which you then move into is called God. That is the spiritual way to talk of God. Otherwise, you can keep talking of God even in material terms—God is this, that, having that property, attached to that religion. All that is a very material description of Godliness.

It's not that the West has not talked of transcending, but it has never talked of transcending *fully*. So, even when there has been a talk of transcendence, it is about transcending *something*. So, transcend the city and enjoy the jungle. It's only the East that has talked of transcending fully, transcending *saṃsāra* itself.

So, an Emerson, for example, transcends, but what does he transcend? Civilization. What does he go to? Physical nature. He says, "I will live in the jungle." When the East transcends, it says, "Not the city, not the jungle, not even within myself." Transcendence is liberation, total and absolute.

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18.

DO SUCCESS AND HAPPINESS GO TOGETHER?

Questioner: Is it necessary to be successful in order to lead a happy life?

Acharya Prashant: Let us first of all understand something. You are assuming that we all want happiness; you are assuming that. That is not a fact. You will feel a little surprised, but I am insisting—we do not want happiness. All we want is freedom from sadness. Because you are sad—that is your real experience, you are sad—you want freedom from sadness. And what do you conclude?

See, we live in a world of duality. If I want freedom from day, what do I get? Night, its opposite. You want freedom from winters. What do you get? Summers, the opposite. So, what you think is that freedom from one thing is a movement into its opposite. That's your assumption.

I am insisting, nobody in this world wants happiness. We want freedom from sadness, and we have erroneously concluded that freedom from sadness means happiness. Because we live in duality, that has been our experience.

Happiness is a kind of an excitement, a tension. You cannot handle too much of happiness. And if you have happiness, then happiness will lose its value. Fact is, you are sad; that is acceptable. You are sad. You want freedom from sadness. But that freedom from sadness is not happiness; that freedom is freedom from sadness and happiness both.

You are saying, “Is it necessary to be successful in order to be happy?”

First of all, see that you want to be successful because you are sad. Because you are sad, so you want to be successful. No man who is not sad will try to be successful. When you are calm, relaxed, loving, in that moment, is there anything called success? Do you bother about success? You don't, right? Success, achievement—these thoughts come to you only when you are

feeling down; only when you feel, “Life has not been good to me”; only when you feel, “I have lost out on something.” Then you say, “I want to be successful,” right?

So, the thought of success itself is a very sad thought. Do you see this? You don’t see this. The thought of success itself arises only in a sad mind. When the thought itself arises from a sad mind, how can this so-called success give you happiness? Just get rid of the sadness. Don’t chase happiness. There is no point chasing happiness. Just get rid of sadness.

And what is sadness? This thought of success. This thought of success itself is sadness. Get rid of it. It arises because of an artificial sense of inadequacy that we have. Unnecessarily we have been forced to believe that this is missing, that is missing.

We find it very hard to accept that life is a simple, continuous, innocent festival. It’s very difficult to accept. We have been trained to accept that life is effort, challenge, war, accomplishment. We will become terrified if told that, “No, no, life is not any of these. You are not here to work hard and attain something; that is not at all why you are here.” You will say, “Then why are we here? Just like this?” Yes, just like this. Relax, dance, enjoy. Nothing more, nothing less.

But even these words are giving you tension. “We will have to relax now? Where to learn that from?” BRE, Bachelors in Relaxation—you need a degree even for that! You have lost all touch with that which is innate.

Will you remember this? Will you figure this out—why do you feel successful, why do you have all these thoughts? Why do you feel that success is important?

The question is so obtuse. A sad mind is saying, “Will sadness give me happiness? Will success give me happiness?” Success itself *is* sadness. Because you are sad, so you want to escape into its opposite. But that will not help. Freedom from a thing is not the same as moving into its opposite. It is a very poor bargain.

“I wanted freedom from day, so I moved into the night”—then nothing has really changed. You were suffering in the day, now you are suffering in the night. How has anything changed? Though everything has changed; you

have moved into the opposite. So, you were suffering in sadness, now you are suffering in happiness. How has anything changed?

And then, again, you will jump back to sadness. For the happy man, it is very important that he becomes sad again; only then the cycle can continue. See, if you want to be happy, then you first must be sad. If you want to be more happy, then you must be more sad. If you want to be happy again, then you must be sad again.

So, the cycle must continue. Only when you are sad will you want to be happy. It is the 'want' that counts. It is the feeling of escape that counts for you. So, sad? "I want to go somewhere else." Where? "In the happy zone." Happy? The mind will plot to move back again to the sad zone. It is the escape that counts. "I must escape somehow!"

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19.

HOW TO OVERCOME REJECTION AND FAILURES?

Questioner (Q): Please guide us on how to overcome rejections or failures at a young age. Youngsters are very susceptible to depression, anxiety, stress, and even suicide. What should they do when they feel that they are failing or being rejected again and again?

Acharya Prashant (AP): See, what is it that you love playing? Any sport you are interested in?

Q: I love cricket.

AP: You love cricket. Tell me of something that you are just not interested in.

Q: I am not interested in basketball.

AP: In basketball. And somebody just pushes you hard to become the top basketball player in the country, and you prepare and train for six months just because you have been pushed to do all that, right? And then you go for the trials and selections and you are rejected there. Now, should you be depressed, or should you celebrate?

Q: Sir, in that case I will just try again.

AP: You will try again for something you have no heart in?

Q: No, in the first place, I will try something that my heart is in...

AP: Right! So, how do you deal with that rejection you got into? You went to basketball trials, and you went to basketball trials just because, let's say your family told you that it is a tradition in our family. "We all have been basketball players. That's your grandpa. Look at the huge thing in his hand; that's supposed to be a basketball. Then that's your granny; she too was a

basketball player, the top one in her village. So, it's a tradition. You have to do it."

So, you go for it and you try for six months and then you get rejected. Apply your wits. Is it a matter of mourning or celebration?

Q: Celebration.

AP: That's how you deal with rejections. You anyway never wanted those things.

So many people write the UPSC. The fact is, they actually never wanted to clear it in the first place. When I was writing one of these exams—I don't remember which one, one of the all India exams, probably UPSC civil services—I think it was my father, he said, "The number of candidates that are appearing appears to be in several lakhs, but it's not against several lakhs you are competing." The number of seats that particular year had been drastically reduced—two hundred or three hundred seats, that's all. The number of applicants was five, eight, ten lakhs, something.

"But then, you are not competing with those many. For these two hundred seats, you are competing with at most two thousand, four thousand applicants, because the others are anyway appearing for namesake. They have filled up the form because their fathers wanted them to, or because they had nothing else, nothing better to do in life and everybody was all the time poking them, 'What are you doing? What are you busy with?' So, they filled out the form and now they can respectfully say, 'You know, I am a UPSC aspirant.'" If these people get rejected, why must they be depressed? You anyway never wanted it!

It appears amusingly stupid to not want something and then get depressed upon not getting it. Think of the situation. There is something that you never heartfully wanted. Had you heartfully wanted it, there is a great probability you would have obtained it. The fact is, you were pushed into it or you just drifted into it. Knowing nothing else to do, you just drifted into it. Some unconscious type of desire pushed you towards a particular target or object. Your heart was never into it. Your consciousness, your discretion was never into it, and that's the primary reason you don't get it.

Obviously, there can be other reasons also, but the primary reason generally is that you never put your whole energy, your entire self into it, because that was not something that you loved from your core. The kind of energy that is needed to uplift life can arise only from a loving core. In some sense, it is only love that can never be defeated or is very, very hard to defeat. That which you call as normal desire is so easy to defeat.

You are desirous of one thing. The salesman displays something more attractive to you. What do you do? Your desire immediately flips, does it not? The same thing does not apply to love because love involves consciousness. You have chosen something after due discretion. You are going for something because you know that the thing is indispensable. It's not just random, whim, fad, fetish; it's a thing of the heart. "I know myself. I know what I need, and I have to go after it. Now, who can stop me?"

Mostly your rejections are worth celebrating. Those were needless burdens, responsibilities put upon you by authoritarian and deceptive forces.

Saint poet Kabir Das, there is a beautiful one from him:

"Bhala hua meri matki phooti; ab main pania bharan se chooti (It's good that my clay pot broke; now I will be free from filling it with water daily)."

He is not getting depressed; he is celebrating.

"And if somebody else had put this pot on my head and entrusted me with the responsibility to daily fetch water from some faraway well or tank or something, and my success was to be measured against my quickness in fetching the water and the fullness of the pot—that was supposed to be a determinant of how successful my life is, right? If I can quickly rush and fetch a lot of water and make multiple trips to that well, get a lot of water and do that quite rapidly, then I would be declared successful. But even if the world declares me successful because of all this pot business, does that fulfill my core? Does it? Does it?"

So, one day that pot falls and breaks, and the poet sings, *"Bhala hua meri matki phooti*—great that I have now been defeated. *Ab main pania bharan se chooti*. This was an external imposition; this is not something I was doing out of love. An artificial duty had been imposed on me: 'You have to be successful this way.' Great, now I have met defeat. Kindly relieve me.

Declare me a failure, tattoo it on my forehead, and let me go. I am okay. Call me a defeat, call me a failure, call me a reject, call me whatever you want to, but spare me. Let me live freely.”

On the other hand, if your target is arising from your core, then it is the love for the target that keeps you going all your life. There can be no rejection because there is always a continuous attempt. So, how can you be depressed? You want something so wholeheartedly that you will never stop trying for it. Now, tell me, where is the rejection? Tell me, where is the final failure?

And that’s probably the only way to live, especially as a young person, no? —to be in love; to do something only because it deserves to be done. And it’s so lovely, so compelling, so beautiful that it becomes irresistible. You cannot not do it. You cannot not love it. Now, tell me, where is failure?

So, the problem does not lie in defeat or failure or rejection; the problem lies in the choice of the goal. The question has to be: Where are your goals coming from? How did something become your goal? How have you started wanting something? How exactly does that happen?

And the quality of your choice depends on the quality of your being, the quality of the chooser within. If you are inwardly asleep, then all your choices will arise from very nebulous, very vague kind of criteria. They would not be choices in the real sense of the word; they would be like the toss of a dice—a three could show up, one could show up, six could show up. Have you chosen? It’s a blind toss. Anything can show up. You have not chosen something; randomly stuff is happening with you.

And in biological life, there is only randomness, just randomness. In conscious life, there is conscious choice arising from a single criterion, and that criteria is freedom. Randomness has no criteria. If there is some criterion, it can no more be called randomness.

In the internal life, there has to be a single criterion, a single criterion against which you determine your choices. What is that criteria? Freedom. Betterment. Liberation. Growth. “Is this making me better? Is this widening, deepening my consciousness? Am I learning something from this? Am I becoming more fearless out of this?” That’s what should determine the choice.

And when your choices come from there, then you can take defeats in your stride. Then you say, "Fine. It's a lifelong journey. It's something I have to continuously do. It's such a humongous project it can never get over." Will you ever say that your love for something has exhausted? You don't want to say that, right?

So, the project has to be an eternal one. Now, what is rejection? What is failure? And it's such an interesting thing, you see. When you make small targets, then you face failures. And when you make huge targets, then there can be no failure. When you make unconscious targets, then there can be failure. But when you make conscious targets in love, then there can be no failure. So, all the failure thing is actually symptomatic of inner sleep.

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20.

SIR, WHAT IF YOUR WORK FAILS?

Questioner (Q): Being an IIT and IIM alumnus, a former civil servant, and then a Vedanta scholar, you have reached many achievements and you have invested a large part of your life into these things. Has this question ever come to you—whether all this has been worth it, or whether it has been a failure? Or what if your work fails? For example, in our particular field, after doing MBBS, people get stressed out about doing PG and then super-specialization. So, didn't you get this kind of a question?

Acharya Prashant (AP): If I am alive, how can my work fail? Failure is a full stop. If I am alive, I am going to try again. Then how have I failed?

You fail not when the results are adverse; you fail when you call it a day. “I am done”—that's the point of failure.

If you love something deeply enough, you are never going to stop trying; so how will you fail? There can be setbacks, there can be bad days—and I have had plenty of them—but there is nothing called a failure. There can be a course correction, there can be introspection, and you can make the next attempt in a different way, in a modified way, right? But what do you mean by failure?

You know, you fail because you set limits. You say, “I am going to invest only this much in this particular project. And having invested this much, if this project gives me what I desire, then I will call it a success; otherwise, I will quit the project.” That's what you call as failure.

Why do you ever quit the project? Tell me. If the project is worthy enough, stay put; don't leave. I have had so many setbacks; I could have quit maybe a hundred times. You need that love, you need to have something worthwhile to do in life, and then thoughts of success and failure do not matter so much. Obviously, you want to succeed, but success then does not remain the central determinant; the central determinant is love.

“Irrespective of success, I will do this because I am choiceless. I have nothing else to do.” Vedanta calls it *nirvikalpatā* (non-differentiation). There is nothing else, no *vikalpa*. Only this is there, no plan B. And when there is no plan B, then by hook or by crook, you make plan A succeed. There is nothing else to do.

Q: If you had to give any advice to your twenty-year-old self, what would it be?

AP: Why do you want to ask me this question? It’s a very smart-sounding question, but how is it related to you? Ask something from your own life. I do not give any advices to my old self.

Q: Well, what advice would you give to me then?

AP: Please tell me about yourself; only then can I advise you.

Q: I am a first-year MBBS student.

AP: Tell me more about yourself. When somebody comes to you—you are a wannabe doctor—a patient comes to you and says, “Give me medicines.” What will you say? What do you say? “Show me your reports. Get yourself checked. Tell me your story.” You will ask for the story of his body. I ask for the story of your mind. And only when you show me your diagnosis, the mental diagnosis, can I then suggest you some treatment, no?

Often it happens that the diagnosis itself is the treatment. Once you know what is going on, the treatment is done, because lack of knowledge itself was the disease. You didn’t know what was going on in the mind, therefore you were diseased. The moment you know what is going on, the problem is solved.

Q: What if a fresher comes to me and he is fine, but he is asking for some advice so that he does not get into any trouble in the future?

AP: Send the fresher to me! Are you the best person to give him advice? So, if a fresher comes to you asking for life advice, I am at your service. Let’s not deal in hypotheses. Reality is what we need. We anyway live in a lot of assumptions. We need to touch base with reality.

Q: How can we get up after falling down and rebound after having a bout of regrets in our lives?

AP: Is it necessary to rebound?

Q: Sir, obviously we need to regain our lives. We cannot remain sad forever.

AP: That's alright—not to be sad the entire life. But is it really important to bounce back and continue doing the same thing?

Q: Sir, I am not talking about doing the same thing; I am talking about coming back to life.

AP: What do you mean by coming back to life? The same kind of life that led to the fall?

Q: I am saying that if we are getting certain setbacks...

AP: Setbacks in doing what?

Q: Anything, any certain things...

AP: No, it's not 'anything'. Wait! You get a setback doing something. What is it that you were doing that didn't materialize? Who were you when you were attempting a certain task? There is a difference between setback and setback. If most of the things that we do are done in ignorance, then those setbacks are indeed good for us.

Think of the catastrophe in case you had succeeded. I am blindly rushing towards a well; I stumble and fall. Is this setback really an unfortunate thing? There is a well five hundred meters ahead of me, and I am rushing towards it in my blindness. Somebody has motivated me, "Rush, reach there!" But because I am in such a hurry to reach, I failed to see that there is a stone. And what does happen? I stumble over it and I fall. What do I do?

We are asking as if it is guaranteed that everything that we do is worth doing. First of all, in humility, let's accept that most of the things that we do are anyway not worth doing. So, if we get a setback, it's actually good news. Good news! That will give you time to pause and reflect. When you get a setback, don't just blindly get up and resume your journey, your rush.

No! See what you are doing and why you must do it. Is it necessary? It's a good opportunity.

Q: How to get rid of the guilt of a wrongdoing?

AP: The guilt of wrongdoing remains only with the one who is still the wrong-doer. Had guilt been real, it would have destroyed the wrong-doer and transformed you into somebody else. You would not have remained to repent over your wrongdoing.

If you do something wrong and you are still repenting over it six months down the line, it means you have not changed. Your repentance is false. Had you been really repentant, you would have no longer remained the same person who did something wrong.

Guilt has a very important role to play in life. You know what guilt means? Guilt is acceptance that "I am not right, I am guilty." Guilt is indictment: "I am not right." Guilt is a recognition that "I am not right." So, guilt is useful because most of us are indeed not right. We need guilt, we need loads of guilt, but we need honest guilt. What is honest guilt? Guilt that transforms us. Not the kind of guilt that shields us.

What is dishonest guilt? Dishonest guilt is when you say, "Oh, I accidentally made a mistake. Why did I make that mistake?" This is dishonest guilt. No mistake is accidental. No wrongdoing is accidental. You are just doing what you are. But we like to say, "Oh, it happened. I didn't do it; it just happened. You know, it was a thing of chance, it happened randomly." Nothing happens randomly. We want to shield ourselves by saying that "I accidentally made a mistake."

Nobody accidentally makes a mistake. The action is the actor; the deed is the doer. If you have done something wrong, then *you* are wrong.

Therefore, guilt is useful. You realize that you are wrong, and then you honestly challenge and change yourself. When that happens, then you are free of repentance; then there is no need to be sorrowful. The one who was sorrowful, he himself has gone, finished. He was the guilty one, and you have sent him away. So who is then left to be guilty?

So, when you feel guilty, feel *fully* guilty. And what does full guilt mean? “I will no more remain the person who did this thing. I will ensure in all ways that this thing is not repeated.” How? By not allowing the offender to continue. “The offender lives here within me. And if he continues to live within me, then I will repeat this act again. So, I will not allow him to live here.” Throw him out. It’s your own sacred space. Evict this mischief-maker.

Q: Is Vedanta only about spirituality? How is it relevant in the modern world?

AP: Vedanta is life. I don’t know what is spirituality. Life—Vedanta is life! And if you are living without knowing, then you are not even living.

So, Vedanta brings life into this human body. Without Vedanta, we are just sitting, walking, eating, sleeping like machines; there is no real life. Life is consciousness. Vedanta is consciousness. Vedanta is life.

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21.

THE EFFECT OF REPEATED FAILURES ON THE SELF

Questioner (Q): In this age of competition, we try very hard for various types of exams, and sometimes it is possible that we come very close but may still end up on the losing side. If that keeps continuing, then won't the repeated failures hamper our self-confidence? If they do, then how to deal with them?

Acharya Prashant (AP): Dealing with repeated failures is not a problem provided you are failing at something worthwhile. The more important question is, what are you failing at? Equally, the more important question is, what are you succeeding at? We just say, "I am successful" or "I am a failure"—why don't we complete the description? What exactly are we successful at? What have we obtained? Or is it so that we didn't bother to go deeply into that and we just went by the commonly, socially accepted definitions of success and failure?

Do what is worth doing and then failure would not mean so much to you. Equally, success too will not mean so much to you. It is the doing that will matter. You will say, "I am grateful I am getting to do what is worth doing. Success or failure depends on a thousand factors, some internal, some external, and I have no handle over all those factors. I may succeed or I may fail; I may have a great role in my success, or I may have no role in my failure." All these permutations are possible. Sometimes, it is possible that you might be the architect of your success; sometimes, it is possible that you are a failure despite all your brilliance.

And you cannot really make this thing deterministic because the world, in that sense, is an open-ended system in which there are not only an infinite number of variables but also a constant flux of interdependent variables. How do you really control them or manage them? You cannot. The only thing you have some authority over is your own self. That self must choose

what to do and what to pick. How does it decide what to pick? By seeing where its own incompletenesses lie.

“If I must be complete, if I must be restful, if I must be genuine and authentic, then what should be the nature of work that I choose for myself? Not work that makes me feel happy as I am, but work that challenges my insecurities, work that chisels me down, work that actually reduces me. Because what is it that I am additionally carrying? I am authentic, and additionally I am carrying a false sense, a borrowed sense of incompleteness. So, I need to choose work that will really challenge my weaknesses. I need not pick up work that is suited to my strengths; I must do that which I am really afraid of doing,” and that is the right definition of work.

Work is not something that you do in order to inflate yourself or to fatten your pockets. Work is something you engage in in order to challenge yourself, reduce yourself, beat yourself, and ground yourself to dust. That is the right definition of work.

And my humble advice to every young person who is about to choose a career or decide on work in life must keep this in mind. See what is it that really troubles you, really, really, and then work should be the medicine for your trouble. That is the way you must choose work.

Therefore, work is not something that you can choose as per the prevailing norms in your hostel or institution or family or country; work is something that you have to choose very individually for yourself. Just as one chooses somebody to love; work should be your first love. And the same principles need to be followed in the choice of your spouse as well. Choose a person who will challenge you, not someone who will pamper you, console you or tell you, “You are beautiful as you are.” And in the very same way, choose work.

Choose work that will really be difficult to handle. Because if it is difficult to handle, then maybe it will not offer you much remuneration, you will not be called an expert, but it will rid you of those parts of yourselves that are weak. In weakness lies fear.

Q: I want everything that I do to be perfect. Because of this, I end up procrastinating a lot of things and focus only on the minor ones that I do

almost perfectly and feel satisfaction only in those things. I am not happy that I am not focusing on the important things in my life. How should I get out of this trap?

AP: No, you should be perfect in the perfect work. First of all, your choice of what you are doing needs to be perfect. If I make a very imperfect choice in the first place and pick up some trivial work to do and then excel in that trivia, what have I attained?

Excellence is important, but in the right field. What will you do by excelling in, let's say, hunting rats? A fellow might say, "I am the world's best rat hunter." Some talent show will come and pick you up and say, "His name needs to go to the Guinness book. He is a great rat hunter!" Most people whom we admire as very talented people or high achievers are exactly this—rat hunters. No doubt they have excellence, but must we not bother to ask: Is this the field you needed to excel in?

If I present a number to you, some random number of, let's say, six digits, and I say this is the money I am going to give to you and you have the choice to change any one digit in this number—it is a six-digit number, it is the money I am going to give to you, and you have a choice to change any one digit in this number—what would you do?

Q: Change the first one to nine.

AP: Change the first one to nine, straight away. So, you know where to excel. Why didn't you change the last one to nine? Because you don't want to be a rat hunter, right?

That is what most of us waste our life doing. If life is a six-digit number, we pick up either the last digit or the second last digit and we spend all our energy and time trying to maximize it. What's more, we succeed in maximizing it. What do we get? The real thing never gets done, the top digit never gets addressed, because society has conditioned us to never look at what is the most important. That goes abegging, unaddressed, and we remain fiercely concentrated on the trivial things in life. And we excel there, and we are feated and admired, felicitated.

So, the delusion that we are somebody and we have achieved something gets even more reinforced. "I think I am somebody, even the society thinks

I am somebody—see what kind of respect they are offering me! See, the magazines are carrying my pics and interviews. See, they are calling me the young leader of the decade.”

Before you excel, ask yourself, “What must I excel in? What is worth it?” Before you speed down a road, ask yourself, “Which road to take?” Speed comes later, choice of the right road comes first. It is far better to be slow on the right road than to be lightning-quick down the wrong road towards your own destruction.

I repeat, making the perfect choice is far more important than being perfect at the perfect choice. Pick up the right project even if you can’t initially excel at it. Instead, you are taught to choose as per your strengths, because that is what the society and the body want. They say, “Pick up something you can excel at.” That is a very, very bad way of decision-making. They say, “Identify your strengths, and make your decisions based on your strengths.” No, what you are actually saying is, “I cannot tolerate being bad at what I do, therefore I will pick up something I can be good at.” You are giving prime importance to your ego. You are saying, “If I am doing something, I must be good at it; else I will feel bad, I will feel low, I will feel insulted, and nobody will respect me.” No, no.

First of all, realize what is it really that must be done—*must* be done—and then pick it up even if you cannot excel at it. Slowly you will learn. It is far better, I said, to be slow on the right road than lightning-quick down the wrong road to your destruction. Being slow is alright; being on the wrong road is not alright. I am not saying that you should be deliberately slow; I am not saying you should be slow for want of effort; I am not giving you a license to be lazy. What I am saying is that the right goal might indeed be so demanding that you might not be able to excel at it, at least initially.

The right goal might not correspond to what your established strengths are. Therefore, you might find yourself struggling initially if you pick the right goal. It doesn’t matter, stay put. Stay put even if you find yourself failing repeatedly. All this comes in the domain of perfection. You are still perfect—how are you perfect? “Irrespective of my repeated failures, I have perfect patience. Irrespective of being beaten twenty times, I am still perfectly in the arena, I have not run away.” This is deeper perfection.

Perfection is not just about winning the championship quickly. Perfection is also about trying again and again, not running away, being the perfect loser. “I lose again and again, but I know that this battle is important; therefore I will stay put perfectly.” This is perfection.

Perfection doesn't lie in the output of the work; perfection lies in your intention. Your intention, your direction should be towards liberation. That liberation itself is called perfection. As long as your intention is directed towards liberation, you are working in perfection. Even if in the eyes of the world you are a defeated one, even if the worldly scorecard shows you to be a continuous loser, you are still in perfection.

So, be in pursuit of perfection by choosing the right work, and the right work is that which leads to perfection. And then don't bother about the results. If you have to lose, keep losing.

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